

THE SKILLS YOU NEED GUIDE TO **PERSONAL DEVELOPMENT**



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Skills You Need

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by Skills You Need available for sale at:**

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Introduction

Personal development is a lifelong process. It is a way for people to assess their skills and qualities, consider their aims in life and set goals in order to realise and maximise their potential.

Early life development and early formative experiences within the family, and in other settings such as at school, can help to shape us as adults. Personal development should not, however, stop later in life.

This book is designed to help you to identify the skills you need to set life goals that can enhance your personal life, employability prospects, raise your confidence, and lead to a more fulfilling, higher quality life. It aims to help you plan to make relevant, positive and effective life choices and decisions for your future, to support personal empowerment.

It contains information and advice to help you to think about your personal development and ways in which you can work towards goals and your full potential.

Using This Book

This eBook can be used to help with thinking about personal development at any level, from a small change like learning a new language for a holiday, to major changes like a new career. The processes and tools described can be used formally or informally, and also in full or in part.

Where appropriate, the book also signposts you to other relevant resources, such as other eBooks available from Skills You Need.

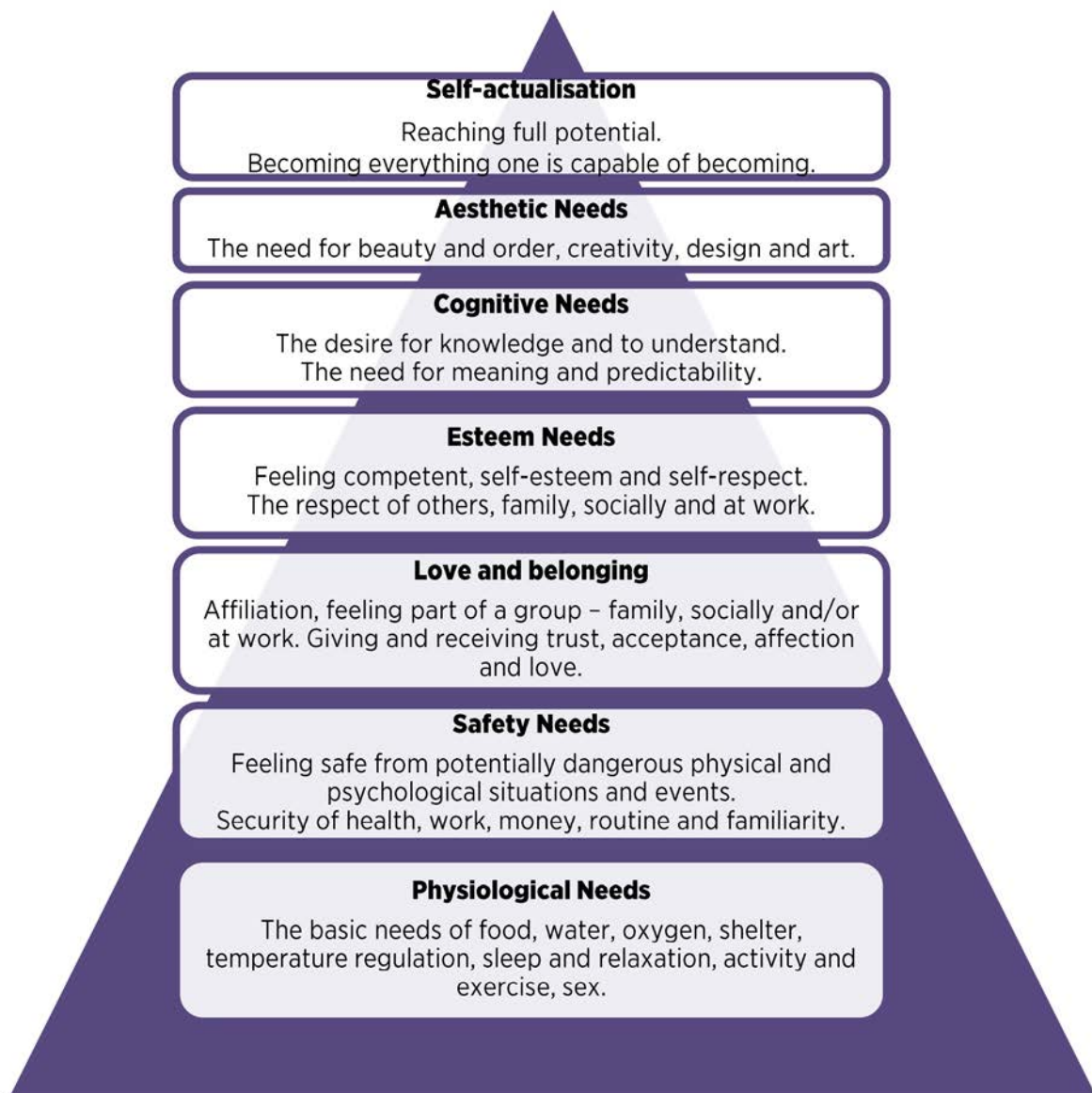
The key is to take what you want and find useful at any given time, and leave the rest.

Why Is Personal Development Important?

There are many ideas surrounding personal development, one of which is Abraham Maslow's process of self-actualisation. Maslow (1970) suggested that all individuals have an in-built need for personal development which occurs through a process called self-actualisation.

The extent to which people are able to develop depends on certain needs being met. These needs form a hierarchy. Only when one level of need is satisfied can a higher one be developed (see Figure 1). As change occurs throughout life, however, the level of need motivating someone's behaviour at any one time will also change.

Maslow's Hierarchy of Needs



The levels are:

- At the bottom of the hierarchy are **the basic physiological needs for food, drink, sex and sleep**, i.e., the basics for survival.
- **Second are the needs for safety and security** in both the physical and economic sense.
- Thirdly, progression can be made to **satisfying the need for love and belonging**.
- The fourth level refers to **meeting the need for self-esteem and self-worth**. This is the level most closely related to 'self-empowerment'.
- The fifth level relates to **the need to understand**. This level includes more abstract ideas such as curiosity and the search for meaning or purpose and a deeper understanding.
- The sixth relates to **aesthetic needs for beauty, symmetry and order**.
- Finally, at the top of Maslow's hierarchy is the **need for self-actualisation**.

Maslow suggested that all individuals need to see themselves as competent and autonomous, and that everyone has limitless room for growth. Self-actualisation is the desire that everybody has 'to become everything that they are capable of becoming'. In other words, it refers to self-fulfilment and the need to reach full potential as a unique human being.

Maslow believed that the path to self-actualisation involved being in touch with your feelings, experiencing life fully and with total concentration.

Managing Your Personal Development

There are a number of steps to take in managing your personal development, and these are covered by the chapters of this book. The steps are:

1. Practical Steps Towards Personal Development

It is easy to make excuses for not getting started on personal development.

Most of us are busy and have any number of other things to do. Chapter 1 explains how you can clear away some of these excuses and get ready to start your personal development.

2. Developing a Personal Vision

Personal development does not have to be for work purposes. It can be for fun, or just because you want to do it. Most of us, however, find it easier to motivate ourselves to learn and improve if we can articulate why we want to do it, whether for work or not. You may, for example, want to develop your writing skills to get a better or different job, learn a musical instrument so that you can play in a band, or learn a foreign language so you can manage better when you go on holiday.

Developing your personal vision—a clear idea of where you want to be in a few months or years, and why—is a crucial part of developing this purpose, and Chapter 2 explains how to start this process.

3. Planning Your Personal Development

Once you are clear about where you want to be, you can start planning how to get there. Drawing up a personal development plan is not essential, and you may feel that it is a step too far for casual development like learning a foreign language or how to play bridge in an evening class.

Having at least some kind of written plan may, however, make it easier to get started, and to see whether you are making progress. Chapter 3 suggests how you might go about this process.

4. Starting the Improvement Process

There are a number of different ways in which you can learn and develop, and Chapter 4 explains how you might go about finding suitable opportunities.

It explores some of the theories about learning, and suggests why different types of learning may be more effective for different subjects or different people. This chapter may be particularly helpful if you are thinking about how to learn a new skill, but none of the options that you have identified really appeals. It may help you to identify new options that you had not previously considered.

5. Reviewing Your Personal Development

For effective learning and development, it is important to reflect on your experience, and consider what you have learnt from it. **Chapter 5 explains that regular review of what you have been doing will help with your learning.**

This may sound excessive for casual development activities like evening classes or online language learning. However, getting into habits of reflection and review will help to ensure that you keep learning from your experiences, whether planned development activity or random events. For more formal learning, or long-term development goals, reviewing your development will also ensure that your activities continue to move you towards your goals, and that your goals or vision remain relevant to you.

6. Recording Your Personal Development

It is often a good idea to keep a record of your personal development, particularly for formal learning. Chapter 6 gives some ideas about how you might do this.

By writing down key developments in your learning and development as and when they occur, you will be able to reflect on your successes at a later date. This reflection may also help to motivate you to learn more skills in the future.

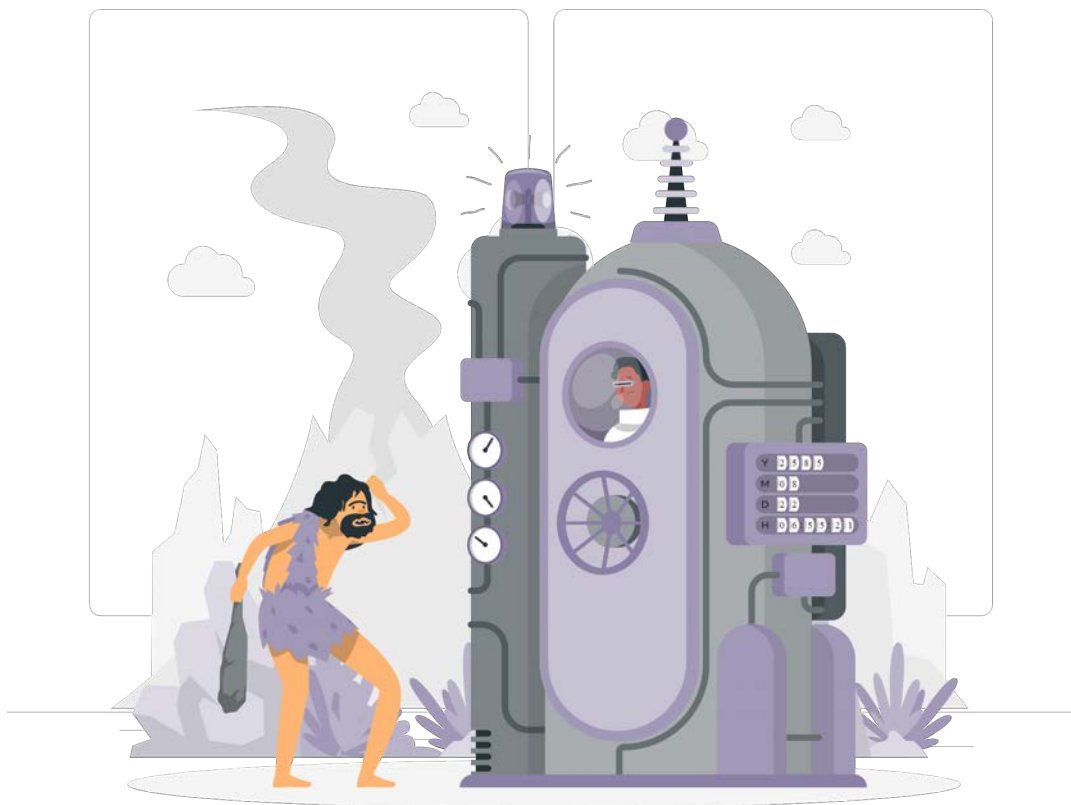
The Journey and the Destination

The process of personal development can sometimes seem challenging, and even a chore.

It is, however, important to remember that the journey matters as much, if not more, than the destination.

- If you are not enjoying the process of personal development, it is hard to remain motivated even if you concentrate on its end point, your goal.
- If you do not enjoy the journey, you may not like the destination very much, either. For example, if you do not like having to play a musical instrument during practice, why would you enjoy playing it in a band?

Personal development is just that: personal and individual. Nobody else can tell you what to do, or whether you will enjoy it. Only you can take responsibility for it, and ensure that it takes you where you want to go.



1

Practical Steps Towards Personal Development

There are a number of things that are vital in supporting your personal development. These include developing a vision of where you want to be, and planning how you are going to get there. Alongside these, it is also helpful to take some simple but practical steps to change how you organise your life.

These changes, outlined in this chapter, will help to give you more time and space to manage your personal development activities. Without that, you may struggle to find the time and energy to improve your skills or study.

For example, you may need to make some changes to the way that you organise your time, to ensure that you have time to practise your new skill.

Organising Your Time

If you are considering making changes in your life, finding additional time often poses a problem. Looking at how you spend your time will encourage you to think of ways your time could be managed more effectively.

The Key to Good Time Management: Understanding the Difference Between Urgent and Important

- **‘Urgent’ tasks demand your immediate attention**, but whether you actually give them that attention may or may not matter.
- **‘Important’ tasks matter, and not doing them may have serious consequences** for you or others. They may, however, not be time-bound.

For example:

- **Answering the phone is urgent.** If you don’t do it, the caller will ring off, and you won’t know why they called. It may, however, be an automated voice telling you that you may be eligible for compensation for having been mis-sold insurance. That would not be important.
- **Going to the dentist regularly is important (or so we’re told).** If you don’t, you may get gum disease, or other problems. However, it is not urgent—but if you leave it too long, it may become urgent, because you may get toothache.
- **Picking your children up from school is both urgent and important.** If you are not there at the right time, they will be waiting in the playground or the classroom, worrying about where you are.
- **Reading funny emails or checking Facebook is neither urgent nor important.** So why is it the first thing that you do each day?

This distinction between urgent and important is the key to prioritising your time and your workload, whether at work or at home. You may want to try using a grid, like the priority matrix (see Figure 2), to organise your tasks into the appropriate categories, and help you decide what to do first.

The Priority Matrix



Using the Priority Matrix

To use the priority matrix, it is best to review your tasks on a daily basis. Each day, ask yourself:

- Which of my tasks needs doing within the next 48 hours?

Those are the 'Urgent' tasks.

- Of the urgent tasks, which ones are more important?

It is a good idea to list your tasks in order of importance, rather than giving them an absolute 'important/not important' distinction.

- Of the non-urgent tasks, which ones are more important?

Again, it is a good idea to list them in order, rather than giving them an absolute distinction.

Now use the answers to these questions to allocate your tasks to the boxes in the priority matrix, following these rules:

- Each box should contain no more than about seven or eight tasks.
- Start with the 'Do Now' box.
- Crucially, don't put off urgent or important things just because they are unpleasant. They won't get any better for procrastinating.
- Next, look at the less urgent but still important tasks. Decide what you are going to do about them, and then schedule time into your diary to do them, or consider delegating them to someone else.
- Delegate the urgent but easier/less important tasks.
- Now eliminate the non-urgent and non-important tasks.
- Finally, do the work. Start your 'Do Now' list. When you finish it, move onto the scheduled work or tasks.

If there are more tasks that you can manage in any quadrant, it is time to a) do some, b) delegate some or c) eliminate some.

Regular pruning of your matrix in this way will ensure that you can focus on what really matters, and keep work flowing.

Remember, too, that you and your health are important. Just because you have lots to do doesn't mean that doing some exercise, going for a 10-minute walk or making time to eat properly is not important. You should not ignore your physical or mental health in favour of more 'urgent' activities.

What can you do if an important task continually gets bumped down the list by more urgent, but still important tasks?

First, consider whether it is genuinely important. Does it actually need doing at all, or have you just been telling yourself that you ought to do it? If it really is important, then consider delegating it.

What about the balance between personal and professional priorities? There are two ways to manage this:

- Include both in the same matrix

Advantages: your personal items do not get lost.

Disadvantages: you will need to find a balance between work and personal items.

- Use two separate matrices, and allocate separate time slots for dealing with each

Advantages: means that you can deal with both, with a realistic view about urgency.

Disadvantages: can get quite complicated.

It is really up to you which you choose—the key is to make it work for you.

Further Principles of Good Time Management

The priority matrix is therefore key to prioritising your workload. However, time management is more than just prioritisation: it is also about being able to work more productively. There are a number of other ways in which you can improve your efficiency and productivity.

- **Keep tidy**

For some of us, clutter can be both a real distraction and genuinely depressing.

Tidying up can improve both self-esteem and motivation. You will also find it easier to stay on top of things if your workspace is tidy, and you keep your systems up to date.

- **Use a 'To Do' list**

Whether electronic or paper, lists are a good way to remember what you've got to do, and to see at a glance what you've forgotten.

Consider highlighting the most important items in some way, and remember to take things off your list when they are complete and/or no longer need doing.

- **Don't procrastinate, but do ask why you're tempted**

If a task is genuinely urgent and important, get on with it.

If, however, you find yourself making excuses about not doing something, ask yourself why. You may be doubtful about whether you should be doing the task at all. Perhaps you're concerned about the ethics, or you don't think it's the best option. If so, you may find that others agree. Talk it over with colleagues or your manager, if at work, and family or friends at home, and see if there is an alternative that might be better.

- **Don't try to multi-task**

Generally, people aren't very good at multi-tasking, because it takes our brains time to refocus.

It's much better to finish off one job before moving onto another. If you do have to do lots of different tasks, try to group them together, and do similar tasks consecutively.

- **Stay calm and keep things in perspective**

Perhaps the most important thing to remember is to stay calm. Feeling overwhelmed by too many tasks can be very stressful. Remember that the world will probably not end if you fail to achieve your last task of the day, or leave it until tomorrow, especially if you have prioritised sensibly.

Take a moment to pause and get your life and priorities into perspective, and you may find that the view changes quite substantially!



Other Ideas to Free Up Time

Some other ideas to try to free up some time include:

- Learning to say 'no' to jobs or requests that you feel are not your responsibility.

This can be hard, because it feels like you are letting people down. Try practising ahead of time, so that you can say, assertively, something like 'No, I'm afraid I won't have time to do that.'

- Learning to delegate.

Sharing jobs can be fun and will leave you with more time. However, it is important that the person to whom you are delegating does not feel that you have 'dumped' on them, and that you are not freeing up your time at their expense.

- Giving up things you do not really want or need to do.

Most of us are guilty of doing quite a number of unnecessary things. Try cutting some of these out of your life.

- Identifying your high and low times of the day.

We all have times when we feel more or less energetic. Try to do the most demanding tasks when you have the greatest energy because you will do them more quickly, and free up more time to spend on other things.

Overcoming Barriers to Learning a New Skill

There are many things that prevent people from learning new skills, but these barriers may be overcome with some thought. They might include:

- **Lack of confidence or self-esteem**

This is one of the greatest obstacles facing many individuals. However, if this is a problem, ask yourself if there is anyone who would support and help you to take the first steps towards learning a new skill. Often, once the first move is made then the greatest hurdle is overcome. Confidence increases as you develop new skills.

- **Economic situation**

You may see your financial situation as a barrier to developing new skills, but this need not be the case.

For example, the internet has lots of free pages and tools and resources that can help you develop specific skills. There may be courses offered in local schools, colleges or universities which are free or offered at a reduced rate for people on a low income. Distance-learning courses allow you to study at home, which can help to reduce the cost of learning. There may also be trust funds or charities that offer grants for people developing new skills in your area. It is even possible to learn a new skill with the aid of books from the local library.

Voluntary work can also provide an excellent opportunity for learning and developing new skills, as can being a member of a local group or society.

- **Family commitments**

If you have family commitments that prevent you from having the time to learn a new skill, it may be possible for you to enlist the help of a friend or family member to give you a few free hours each week. Colleges and universities offering vocational training courses may also have free or subsidised crèche places.

The First Step is Often the Hardest...

Barriers to personal development are often more in the mind than anywhere else.

The first step—whether it is signing up for a course, getting some books from the library, or finding a website that can help—is often the hardest. As you take that first step, remember that the process is described as ‘lifelong’ for a reason: you are always learning, it is only the level of formality that changes.



Barriers or Excuses?

Many of these barriers may be more excuses than fundamental blockages.

If you are using any of these as reasons for avoiding development, it may be worth looking deeper to see if there are reasons for your thinking, perhaps deeply held values that may be in conflict with personal development.



Developing Your Personal Resilience: An Important Step Towards Personal Development

A key challenge and barrier to personal development is fear of what might happen. What if you fail? How will you cope?

The answer to this is learning to develop your personal resilience, or ability to bounce back from disaster or setbacks. Put simply, resilience is the ability to cope with and rise to the inevitable challenges, problems and set-backs you meet in the course of your life, and come back stronger from them.

Resilience relies on different skills and draws on various sources of help, including rational thinking skills, physical and mental health, and your relationships with those around you.



Four Ingredients of Resilience

There are four basic ingredients to resilience:

- **Awareness.** Noticing what is going on around you and inside your head;
- **Thinking.** Being able to interpret the events that are going on in a rational way;
- **Reaching out.** How we call upon others to help us meet the challenges that we face, because resilience is also about knowing when to ask for help; and
- **Fitness.** Our mental and physical ability to cope with the challenges without becoming ill.

Understanding these four elements means that you can start to avoid so-called ‘thinking traps’, or traps where your thinking becomes stuck in an unhelpful rut, or triggers particular emotions.

The benefit of understanding that these thoughts lead to these particular emotions is that we can understand our subconscious thought processes by identifying the emotion we feel. This may not be obvious otherwise, and it will help us to take the right action to address the problem.

Thinking traps are effectively assumptions about ourselves or the situation, made without examining the evidence, and are usually unhelpful. We can overcome them by applying logic to the situation, and gathering more information before reacting.

We can also improve resilience by reaching out to others and asking for help when we need it.

The final element of resilience is physical and mental health: simply keeping ourselves fit and well so that we can manage challenges more easily.

“No man is an island, entire of itself. Every man is a piece of the continent, a part of the main...”

John Donne (English poet)



Seven Pillars of Resilience

Another model of resilience, which may be particularly helpful in a personal development context, is the seven pillars of resilience. These are:

- Realistic optimism
- Acceptance
- Solution orientation
- Self-regulation
- Assuming responsibility
- Network orientation
- Future planning

1. Realistic optimism

Realistic optimism helps us to avoid unnecessary fears and self-imposed obstacles that hold us back from achieving our goals. If we look at challenges with the attitude of ‘that won’t work’, we tend to fear the results and might not even try to start achieving them.

Unrealistic optimism, however, can potentially lead to risky behaviour and unwanted consequences.

There are several ways to change yourself from a pessimist to an optimist. For example, you might want to work on your core beliefs to help you change your mindset. You could also keep a diary recording the nature of your thoughts through the day. This helps to identify negative thoughts and projections and enables you to turn them into positive ones. Meditation can also support this process.

2. Acceptance of the unchangeable

There are situations that might bother us, but we have to accept that we don’t have any realistic chance of changing them. Dwelling on them simply keeps you unsatisfied.

We can help ourselves by accepting these circumstances as unchangeable!

3. Solution orientation

Having a solution orientation is a choice. Do I want to dwell on the problem and waste my time, or do I want to look at solutions and move on?

4. Self-regulation

This pillar contains the abilities of self-motivation, managing stress, self-discipline and self-control.

This pillar can be strengthened through goal setting, boundary setting and accountability to ourselves. A life without goals easily tends to become dull.

5. Assuming responsibility

We all know people who always blame others for their failures.

Basically, this is often a symptom of lacking the fourth pillar of resilience. Self-responsibility is an important aspect of getting out of a crisis quickly, because it enables us to accept wrong doings and find quick actions for solutions. The it's-their-fault trap keeps us in an irresponsible state without much action.

6. Network orientation

Network orientation is important in enabling you to get help in a crisis.

An important aspect of the fifth pillar, accepting responsibility, is the ability to reach out to others and ask for help by admitting that there might be a crisis. Network orientation helps you to find solutions that cannot be found on your own.

7. Future planning

Goal setting can be the antidote to a lack of motivation and even depression. A clear vision of the future helps us wanting to live life, overcome obstacles and look forward and not backwards.



Assessing Resilience

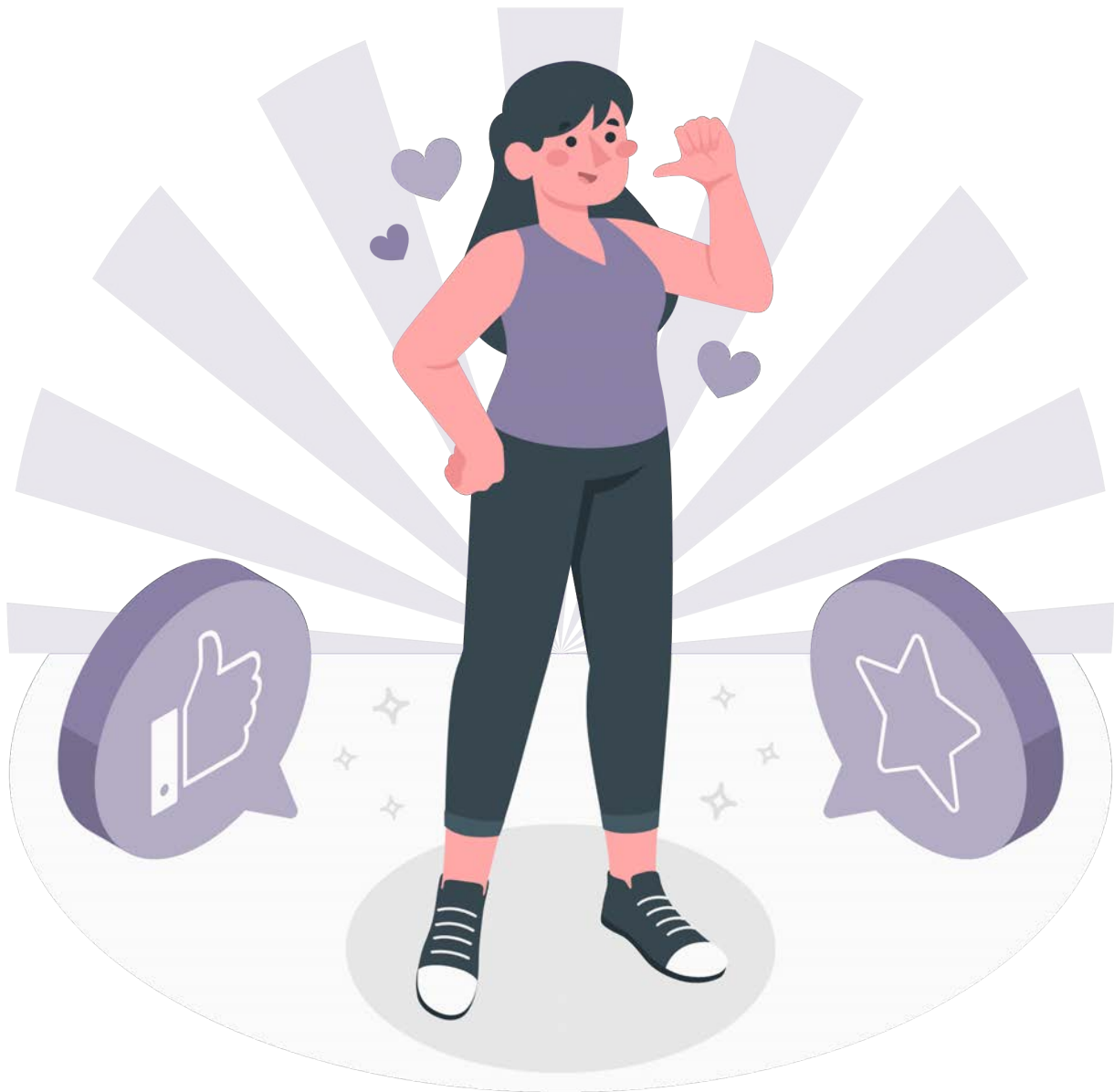
You can gauge your resilience by giving yourself a score for each of these pillars from 0 to 10, where 0 is 'not good at all', and 10 is 'I do this routinely', and then summing your seven scores.

Anyone achieving over 45 points can consider themselves to be fairly resilient. Anyone below 55 points could benefit from working on their resilience.

Conclusion

Improving your resilience can be an important support to taking that first step towards personal development. It will help you to overcome concerns about possible failure and allow you to start on your personal development journey with more confidence.

Paradoxically, many of the elements of personal development discussed in this book, like goal-setting, are also helpful in developing more resilience.



Top Tips for Personal Development

Sometimes it can be hard to know where to start with personal development.

When you are planning development for work purposes, should you try to eliminate your weaknesses, or focus on your strengths and build them up even further? Outside work, should you try to improve your skills in something you already love doing, or learn something completely new?

You may by now be in a state of ‘analysis paralysis’ and not at all sure what to do next.

This section provides some tips on personal development to help you to get started, and then keep going by focusing on what matters.

1. Think about why you are trying to develop

It is important to think about *why* you are starting any kind of process of personal development.

The answers to all the questions about ‘what’ and ‘where’ (What should I do? Should I address my weaknesses, or build my strengths? Where should I begin?) all become clearer once you identify why you want to change.

Learning in and of itself can be interesting and fun, but many of us want to develop and improve for a specific purpose. It is important to be clear about this purpose, so that you can assess whether your learning and development activities are moving you closer to your goals. It is also easier to get motivated when you have a clear picture of where you want to be at the end of the process.

Chapter 2 provides more information about this process.

2. Writing something down can make it seem more realistic

Preparing a personal development plan may seem excessive for starting a simple evening class, but writing down what you plan to do and why will help to make it more realistic.

There is something about writing things down that makes any exaggeration look ridiculous, and the unrealistic stand out like a sore thumb. Making a plan for your personal development, including time limits and stages of development, will force you to be realistic about what you can achieve by when.

Writing it down does not bind you irrevocably. Everyone’s lives change, and your priorities may well alter after you have developed your plan. A written plan, however, gives you something to look back on and a way of keeping tabs on your goals, even formally altering them if necessary.

Chapter 3 provides more information about this.

“I may not have gone where I intended to go, but I think I have ended up where I needed to be.”

Douglas Adams

3. Think about what works for you

It is important to find out what personal development methods work best for you.

There is an enormous range of development activities available, from formal training sessions, through online training to experiential learning, reading and discussing ideas with others. As with anything, it is important to find out what works best for you—as in, what you enjoy most and also what helps you to learn and develop quickly and effectively.

By documenting your experience, including feedback from other people about your progress, you can also compare and contrast different types of learning and experience.

Chapter 4 provides more information about how you can work out what works for you.

4. Writing down your thoughts during the process can help later

Keeping track of your plans and ambitions, and how you felt about various activities can feel like hard work, especially for informal learning.

Keeping detailed records may well be something that you would prefer to avoid.

However, it is a good idea to get into a habit of reflecting on your activity and learning each week or month, whether formal or informal, and writing down your thoughts. Reviewing your original plans, however casual they were, and your thoughts about what you have learned or done, will show you how you have changed over time, and the progress that you have made.

It is incredibly easy to forget how you felt about things at different stages, and even why you thought a particular goal was important. Writing down your thinking will help to show you what works best, and what you have enjoyed and disliked. It may even point you towards more suitable activities or areas for development.

Chapter 6 explains more about this.

5. It is important to focus on what is really important to you

What is really important in your personal development?

Personal development is a lifelong process—which is why it is sometimes described as ‘lifelong learning’. In practice, this means you do not have to do everything at once, although it can be hard to remember this.

Use your personal vision—however informal—to identify what really matters now. This will tell you what you have to do first to achieve your vision, and you can then concentrate on that. Only once you have achieved that, or at least made reasonable progress, should you move on. ‘Butterfly-style’ personal development, flitting from subject to subject, may keep you interested, but will probably be less satisfying or effective in the longer term.

Chapter 2 explains more about the process of developing your vision.

6. Grasp new opportunities

Do not be afraid to take opportunities that you had not considered before.

Not everything in life, or personal development, is predictable. Sometimes you may be offered an amazing opportunity to do something that does not fit with your immediate priorities, but which sounds too good to miss.

It is worth considering whether taking this opportunity will slow down your progress towards your ultimate goal and, if so, whether that matters.

It is not worth turning something down simply because you have never thought of doing it, and therefore it does not feature in your ‘life plans’.

Ultimately, being offered this kind of opportunity probably helps you to define your goals better: if it sounds very exciting and you really want to do it, then do. If it changes your goal and vision, so be it.

**“Our biggest regrets are not for the things we have done
but for the things we haven’t done.”**

Chad Michael Murray

7. Let your personal development evolve

Your priorities will change—and that is fine.

Few, if any, of us would say that we were exactly the same person at 35 that we were at 15, or even 25. As you grow and change, taking on new responsibilities in work or at home, so your priorities and goals will change.

The key is to recognise that this is fine.

What matters is to ensure that your personal development activities continue to take you where you want to go, and that you continue to enjoy the journey.

Chapter 5 contains more about the importance of reviewing your plans and progress regularly.



2

Developing a Personal Vision and Goals

It is important to have a vision for your future. A vision here means a picture of what and where you want to be in life. You might think of this as identifying what success looks like for you in work, in your personal life, or perhaps in sport and hobbies.

This does not have to be a huge, formal written document setting out every last detail. It might be as simple as saying 'I would like to spend more time playing music', or even 'I like my life as it is, and I do not want it to change fundamentally'. Your vision simply has to show you what you want you or your life to be in the future. You can then take steps to 'make it so'.



Standing Still May Take Positive Effort

Remember that even keeping your life the same may need positive action. You cannot, for example, expect to retain the same standard of living if you are not prepared to put in some effort at work.

If you are happy in a relationship, and wish to remain so, you need to keep working at it. We can think of life as a river. There is a natural flow that will inevitably affect us. Action is necessary to remain in the same place.

Your vision is a vital step on the way to identifying your personal development needs, and then taking action to address them.

This chapter explains how you can develop and refine that personal vision and help to define 'success' for yourself.

Defining Success



success, n. any favourable development or outcome, something that turns out well or that is judged favourably by others.

Chambers English Dictionary, 1988 edition

It may be obvious, but it is worth pointing out that success looks different for all of us.

Each of us has different ambitions and things that we want to achieve and to get out of life. For this reason, it is unhelpful to compare your achievements to others, or to consider others as ‘unsuccessful’ because they have not achieved what you want to achieve. However high others may reach in life or careers, you also have no way of judging whether they consider their own lives a success.



Defining Success

Nelson Mandela can, by most measures, be considered a success: the first president of post-apartheid South Africa, a key mover in securing the end of apartheid and, on a personal level, a survivor of many years in the notorious prison on Robben Island.

He himself, however, said merely,

‘When a man has done what he considers to be his duty to his people and his country, he can rest in peace. I believe I have made that effort and that is, therefore, why I will sleep for the eternity.’

Vision, and success, is extremely personal.

Different Areas of Success

As well as success being personal, there are many different ways in which it could be defined and measured: fame, fortune, recognition, personal integrity, discovering something new to the world, or even just doing your job to the best of your ability.

It is important to be clear about what ‘success’ would look like to you.

As the first step to developing your vision, it may be worth thinking about how success will look. Consider as many aspects of it as possible, but also identify the one that is most important to you (money, fame, family etc.).

Success will also look different across different areas of your life. It may be helpful to identify particular areas, and think about them separately. Useful distinctions include:

- Formal or informal study and learning
- Career or professional life
- Personal life and relationships
- Hobbies or sport



Life Goals and Vision

Life goals and vision are closely linked:

- A life goal is broadly what you want to achieve in the course of your life, whether in the short- or long-term.
- A vision is how you see yourself in the future.

Your vision might therefore include one or more life goals, or you might decide that part of your vision is not to have any life goals and live life in the moment.

Inspiration and Influence

In thinking about success, it may be helpful to think about people who have influenced you, and also people whom you find inspiring.

These may be:

- **People you know**, who have said or done things that have affected how you perceive success, or what you want to achieve in life;
- **People in the public eye**, who you may wish to emulate in some way, or take steps to avoid doing what they have done; and
- **Historical or even fictional characters** whom you feel are particularly like or unlike you, or who did particularly good or bad things.



Positive and Negative

Influence can be both positive and negative.

It is important to be aware of why you perceive success in particular ways, or want to achieve particular things.

In particular, you want to be aware if your ambitions have perhaps been driven by trying to please others. This is not necessarily a bad thing, but it is important to be aware of it.

In each case, think about why you find these people influential or inspiring. This is not particularly about what they have done, but about how you feel about it.

How to Use Your Vision

At this stage, you should have a broad picture of what success will look like for you in each sphere of your life, and which elements are most important to you. This, roughly, is your vision.

You can think of your vision as the picture on the cover of the jigsaw box.

It guides you and gives you an overall picture of what you are trying to achieve. When it comes to actually putting the pieces together, however, you have to rely on the way that they look and how they fit together in practice: the picture is probably not detailed enough to help.

In other words, your vision needs to give you a broad outline of where you are going: what sort of life you want, how you want to live, and what you want to achieve. It does not, however, have to be in huge detail.



Flexibility is Vital

Your vision is the guide that keeps you to the path despite new and challenging information. However, it should also be open to change when you receive new information about yourself.



Changing the Vision

Until she had children, Melanie had been a real career woman.

A high-flyer, she had worked as a civil servant and always been first to volunteer for high pressure, high visibility jobs. Although she had plenty of hobbies, and an active social life, work came first. When asked, she said that she saw herself progressing through the civil service, onwards and upwards.

But once children arrived, her priorities changed. She no longer wanted to work long hours, or even full time. The job which she had enjoyed so much just didn't fulfil her anymore. She found herself resenting her time in the office, and worrying about how she was going to survive the next twenty years.

When her employer offered voluntary redundancy, she decided to take up the offer. To allow herself a complete break, she took 18 months out to spend time with her children. After that, she looked carefully around at her options, and decided to start her own business. She realised that she now saw success as being able to spend time with her children, attend events at school, and be there when the children arrived home each day, while still doing something that kept her brain active, and allowed her to earn enough money to meet the family's needs.

She admitted freely that she would never have expected to define success in that way. Recognising that her vision had changed, however, had given her the freedom to do something that met her needs, and those of her family.

Refining Your Personal Vision

Your vision is your guide to developing your personal strategy. It helps you to ensure that what you do gets you where you want to be.

However, if your vision is like the picture on the jigsaw, and not at all detailed, you may be wondering how you move from that to setting defined goals, if you wish to do so. This section explains how this process works.

The first step is to develop more clarity about where you see yourself over the next few months and years. This allows you to set out some expectations for both the long-term (five to ten years) and shorter term. The best way is to start with the longer term, and then work backwards.

1. Setting the long-term vision

Ask yourself the question:

- Where do I see myself in five [or ten] years' time?

Consider each aspect of your life: personal, professional, hobbies, other interests, formal study and so on. Even if you only want to change one aspect, it can be helpful to think about your whole life, to see if your ambition to change fits with the rest of your activities and thinking.

For each one, try to describe what you will be doing, and what you want to have achieved. Be as precise as possible with what you want to achieve, including the standards you want to reach. This is only for you: nobody else will ever see it, so be as ambitious as you like.

Aim for three to five bullet points in each aspect of your life, but do not worry if you have fewer or more.

This tells you what 'success' will look like at the end of that time period.

It is also helpful at this stage to think about how important each of these aspects is to you. If you could only achieve in one area, which would it be, and why?



Choosing Your Time Horizon

It does not really matter whether you opt for five or ten years. It really depends how comfortable you are with a longer time horizon.

Many people prefer five, because they have a clearer idea of what they want to achieve. Every now and then, however, it is a good idea to think about a ten-year horizon. This forces you to confront issues about the balance between work and personal life, and what you really want to achieve in your life overall.

2. Identifying interim success

Next, using your five- or ten-year vision as a guide, ask yourself:

- *What will I need to have done in one year [and five years] if I am to be there in five years [or ten years]?*

This gives you some 'staging posts' on the way to your long-term vision. In other words, it shows you what your interim 'success' will look like. It is fine to have plenty of 'probably' and 'might' at this stage, but keep the language positive.

This question can be answered in terms of both achievements and actions that you will need to take. You will probably end up with a mixture of the two. Make sure that you have at least one achievement or action for each of your bullet points, and that you have listed everything that you need to do or achieve.

3. Breaking it down still further

Finally, break your timing down still further. Ask yourself:

- *What will I need to have done after six months, three months and one month to reach my one-year and five-year vision?*

Again, look at both actions and achievements, and try to be as specific as possible about all the interim steps.

4. Reviewing the outline

At the end of this process, you should have a series of time-bound bullet points. These will tell you where you need to be, and what you need to have achieved, to reach your five—or ten—year vision.

The final step is to review what you have written. Ask yourself:

- *Does it look realistic?*
- *Do I think I can achieve what I need to achieve within one month, three months, six months, and a year?*

If not, revise those bullet points and, if necessary, tweak your ultimate vision too.

Perhaps more to the point, do you feel comfortable with what you have identified that you need to do, and to achieve? Will you be happy and fulfilled as you move towards your vision? Are you excited about getting started?

If the answer to any of these questions is no, then it is a good idea to have another look at your vision. Ask yourself:

- *Am I really being honest about what I want to achieve?*
- *Have I said this because I want to achieve it, or because I think I ought to do it?*

Obligation is a strong motivator, and it might have happy results, but you do need to be aware of it.

5. Turning your vision into goals

This process gives you a clear idea of where you want to be at various time points. The next step is to turn that vision into specific goals.

This process is set out in more detail in the next section.



The Importance of Opportunities

Your vision acts as a set of guiding principles for what you do in life.

If your vision is important to you, then each action or opportunity is measured against whether it will help you achieve your vision or not. This process may be subconscious, but you can be sure that it will be happening, *provided that your vision is important.*

However, you are also likely to be presented with opportunities in life that may sound like they would be fun, or interesting, or just that you would like to do.

If so, this may be the point to update your vision.

After all, if you never envisaged this opportunity, you could not possibly include it in your vision. If it excites you, give yourself the option, because it may lead you down new paths that suit you very well.

Your vision needs to be at least broadly adaptable, and open to change in response to new opportunities.

Setting Personal Goals

Once you have a vision, refined down to action points over the next few months and years, your next step is to set some personal goals.

There is a strong correlation between self-motivation, personal goals and achievement. We all have an inbuilt desire to achieve. What we want to achieve, however, is personal to us and may change through life. At school, for example, you may want to achieve good grades, then later you may want to pass your driving test or get a job.

It is important to set yourself clear goals if you wish to achieve your ambitions.

The Relationship Between Motivation, Goals and Achievement

People want to know that they have achieved, or have the ability to achieve, something of value, meaning or importance.



Achievement and Confidence

Generally, the more people achieve, the more self-confident they become. As self-confidence rises so does the ability to achieve more.

Conversely, when people fail to achieve and meet their goals, self-esteem and confidence can suffer, affecting their motivation to achieve more.

Understanding the relationship between self-motivation, personal goal-setting and achievement will help you set realistic personal goals, which in turn will allow you to achieve more in the longer term.

Personal goals can provide long-term direction and short-term motivation.

Goals help us to focus on what we want to be or where we want to go with our lives. They can be a way of using knowledge, and managing time and resources, so that you can focus on making the most of your potential.

By setting clearly defined personal goals, you can measure your achievements and keep sight of your progress. If you fail to achieve at one step, you can reassess your situation and try new approaches. Keeping your life goals clearly defined and updated as your circumstances change and evolve is one of the most powerful ways to keep yourself motivated throughout life.

Making Your Goals Smart

It can be useful to make your goals and sub-goals fit the SMART criteria. These are:

S

SPECIFIC

Make each goal specific, so you know exactly what it is.

Take some time to clearly define your goals and sub-goals. Having more detail about your goals and how you intend to achieve them is always better.

M

MEASURABLE

Make each goal measurable, so you know how you are progressing.

You need to be able to see how you are progressing towards your goals. What metrics can you use to measure your progress?

A

ATTAINABLE

Do not set yourself impossible goals. Make sure each goal and sub-goal is attainable.

Large goals often seem nearly impossible, but if you break them down into simple sub-goals, each step becomes more attainable. Stretch goals are fine—and in fact the evidence suggests that they are significantly more motivating—but you should definitely be able to see a way to achieve your goals, however challenging that will be.

R

RELEVANT

Make your goals relevant.

Ensure your sub-goals are relevant to your life goals. Try not to set goals that do not ultimately help you to achieve your overall life goals. If you find that you want to achieve other things on the way, it may be that your overall life goals are not quite right for you.

T

TIMED

Set time-limits or deadlines for each goal and sub-goal.

If you can set and stick to realistic deadlines, you will avoid too much distraction or procrastination and keep yourself motivated.

Reviewing Your Goals

Finally, review your goals and make sure that they motivate you and excite you. If that is not the case, you are not going to bother doing the work necessary to achieve them.

In a year's time, it will not matter if you have not had as much time as you would have liked to devote to learning to play the piano; it *will* matter if you haven't done anything towards it because you're really not that bothered about it.



The Acid Test

If your goals don't excite you, abandon them, and start again. Develop new ones that you really want to achieve.

The next chapter covers the process of turning your goals into a plan for development.

3

Planning Your Personal Development

Improving your skills—a practice known as personal development—does not happen by itself.

Some personal development can be a matter of being in the right place at the right time, and simply taking up opportunities. However, consistent, effective personal development across a wide range of skills requires deliberate and focused effort.

This chapter explains the importance of planning your personal development in order to achieve your vision, goals and ambitions in life, whether career-focused or more personal.

Why Plan?

At various points in your life, you may be presented with opportunities for personal development: perhaps the chance to work with someone particularly inspiring, or to do something new and unexpected.

However, it is also true to say that you make your own luck.

“The more you work, the luckier you get.”

Attributed to golfer Jerry Barber in 1960

In other words, you have to know what you need to improve to achieve a particular ambition, and then work on it. If you do so, you will improve.

Only by doing so will you have a chance of achieving that ambition, or taking up that opportunity should it present itself.

On the other hand, if you really do not know what you need to improve, you cannot work on it. And if you do not plan ahead to develop the skills that you need for your chosen course in life, you will not be able to achieve all that you want.

The reason for planning your personal development is therefore very simple: only you know what you want to achieve, and the key to achieving it is in your hands, via the actions you take. Planning what you need to do to achieve your goals is a vital step in the process.

Many people may first come across personal development plans as part of a course of study, or at work. However, planning what you need to do to improve or change yourself is not just important in formal situations. It can also help in your personal life too.



Why You Wouldn't Need a Personal Development Plan

There may well be times in your life when you do not feel the need for a personal development plan. You might, for example, finish a course of study, or reach a point in your personal life where you consciously decide that for the moment, you do not want to do anything deliberate by way of personal development.

In the nature of things, you will of course continue to learn from everything that happens to you, every day. This is why it is called 'lifelong learning'.

However, you may choose not to document it, or to work towards any particular goals, and that is fine.

Remember, though, that when you do want to improve particular skills, planning will help you to achieve your goals.

Elements of Your Personal Development Plan

There are a number of things that you need to include in a personal development plan. These include:

- A **clear vision** of where you want to be and why;
- A good understanding of the **skills you need to develop** to achieve your vision;
- A clear idea of the **standard you need to achieve**, and how different that is from your current standard;
- A **level of priority** for each area; and
- A **detailed idea** of how to get from where you are now for each skill or area, to where you want to be.

It is worth considering each of these in turn.

1. Developing Your Vision

As Chapter 2 explained, it is really helpful to think about where you want to be and what you want to do. It can be useful to think in terms of different lengths of time: for example, one month, six months, one year, five years. It is also helpful to make your vision as detailed as possible, across all spheres of life: career, where you want to live, your hobbies and even relationships.

The more detail you can include, right down to how you will feel about it, the easier it will be to hold onto your vision when times are hard.

2. Identifying Skills for Development

The next step to your personal development plan is to think about what skills you need to develop, and why this is important to achieving your vision.

For example:

- Do you need certain skills to get a particular job, or to advance in your chosen career?
- Are you planning to live abroad, and therefore need to develop your language skills?
- Are you struggling to manage a particular situation, and need new skills to help?
- Have you been told that you lack particular skills and need to develop them to work effectively with others, or on your own?

It is important to make sure that the skills you are targeting are clearly linked to a purpose, which is in turn linked to your vision. Without this clarity, your personal development efforts may fail. In particular, you may not concentrate on the right skills, or be fully aware of your timescale.

3. Identifying Strengths and Weaknesses

If knowing where you want to be, and establishing your personal vision, is the first step in any personal development, the next step is to understand where you are now. From this point, you can work out which areas are likely to need some work to improve your skills and abilities.

Being aware of your strengths and weaknesses—and, indeed, wider self-awareness—is a crucial part of emotional intelligence. Without a good understanding of yourself, it is very hard to either improve, or to respond effectively to others.

Cultivating habits of reflection, self-awareness and understanding is therefore important for relationships throughout life.

Being aware of your weaknesses enables you to take steps to start to address them. These steps may be through formal courses, working out how to use and apply your existing experience in a different way, or using everyday experiences and setbacks as a way to learn.



Don't Forget Your Strong Points

In identifying areas to work on, it is also important to recognise your strong points: where you already have very good skills or some particular expertise. These are, after all, the skills that are likely to get you where you want to be.

This will help:

- To avoid you feeling as if all you do is criticise yourself; and
- To identify where you might be able to draw on previous experience to develop new skills.

Some experts recommend a long list of things that you are good at, and a much shorter list of only four or five areas for development. This helps you to remain positive. There is more about this in *The Skills You Need Guide to Career Management*.

One way to identify your strengths and weaknesses is through a personal swot analysis.

SWOT analysis is the examination of your situation by looking at Strengths, Weaknesses, Opportunities and Threats. It has been used by businesses for many years as a strategic planning tool because it helps to give you an all-round view of the organisation.

SWOT analysis is, however, equally useful on a personal level as a way to identify areas for development, and as part of career discussions. Its simple format, and easy-to-apply structure mean that it can be used very easily without support.



A Summary of SWOT Analysis

SWOT analysis is a way of looking at your situation by identifying:

- Strengths, or those areas where you have an advantage over others, or some unique resources to exploit;
- Weaknesses, or areas where you may be weaker than others, and may find that others can do better than you;
- Opportunities, or possibilities that you can take advantage of to help you achieve your goals and ambitions; and
- Threats, or things that may prevent you from achieving your goals.

A personal SWOT analysis may be most useful if you focus on a specific goal or problem that you want to address. This is because we all have a number of very diverse goals. The skills and attributes that may help us towards one goal may be irrelevant, or even a weakness, in another context. A threat in one context could be unimportant in another.

Going through the SWOT process (see box) for a particular goal and/or problem enables you to identify which areas are really bothering you, and where you most need to focus your attention.

You can use the process for every goal, but it may be more helpful to use it only when you find a problem particularly challenging. It is, effectively, a way of ordering your thinking, and helping you to see the problem in a slightly different way.





The SWOT Process

1. Identify the goal that you want to achieve

It is important to be as specific as possible. Be clear about timing, that is, when you want to achieve your goal, and also how you will know that you have achieved it (your success criteria).

Thinking specifically about that goal:

2. Identify the personal strengths that will help you to achieve it, and the weaknesses that could prevent you

It is often helpful to consider knowledge, skills, experience, resources and support that you have available. If you list these headings separately, you will remember to consider them all.

These areas are generally internal. That is, they relate to you personally, and the resources and skills that are available to you. They are, therefore, things that are generally under your control.

It is important to be honest about these skills. Are they really up-to-date, or might you need to do some work before you could rely on them?

3. Identify any personal opportunities that could enable you to achieve the goal, and also that you will be able to take advantage of when you have achieved it

Opportunities are generally external, relating to the environment and those around you, rather than to you yourself. They include things like promotions and financial incentives and events that are likely to happen at work or outside, such as someone going on maternity leave or sabbatical, that might mean you have a chance to do something new.

In identifying opportunities that might open up as a result of achieving your goal, consider both short- and long-term benefits.

4. Identify any threats

These are external things and events that are worrying you, or that might happen and prevent you from either achieving your goals, or taking advantage of the benefits.

5. Review and prioritise

Finally, as always with development activities, and anything that looks like strategic thinking, it is a good idea to review your analysis. Ask yourself:

- Is this recognisably me?
- Is there anything that I have forgotten?

And finally:

- Which areas are most important in each of the four categories in the analysis?

Try to highlight one, or at most two, things from each of strengths, weaknesses, opportunities and threats that you think will be most important in achieving (or preventing you from achieving) your goal.

The process of identifying areas for improvement, including a personal SWOT analysis, can be done on your own.

However, it is worth bearing in mind that any analysis is stronger if it draws on outside evidence. Your personal analysis is therefore likely to be more powerful if you draw on the views of others.

If, for example, you are part of a learning group at work, or at college or university, you can agree to go through the process for each other in turn. You can even gather evidence from each other's colleagues to support the analysis.

If you are doing this by yourself, you may want to ask friends and colleagues their views on your strengths and weaknesses, or ask them to comment on your first draft analysis and suggest additions.



Getting Feedback

It can be difficult for people to give you feedback about strengths and weaknesses face-to-face, especially at short notice. It may feel like they are over-praising you, or picking holes in you, and people do not like to do either of those things.

You may therefore want to:

- **Explain what you want ahead of time, and ask if people are prepared to talk to you honestly.** If possible, give them some areas to focus on (for example, you would like to know more about how you come across to other people, or what it is like to work with you). You will need to respect their decision if they prefer not to comment.
- **Set up a one-to-one discussion over a coffee,** having given them enough time to prepare.
- **Ask a trusted friend to collate written feedback anonymously.** If you go down this route, you may find that a useful format is 'Keep, Stop, Start'. Here, you ask people to give two or three comments on things that you should keep doing, stop doing and start doing.

4. The Size of the Challenge

Having identified an area for development, you also need to know what standard you need to achieve, and how different that is from your current standard.

The difference between where you are now and where you need to be tells you the magnitude of the task. It therefore affects how long it will take, and also how much effort you need to put in.

For example, if you are planning to move abroad in a year's time, or go travelling, you may need to develop your language skills. But:

- **If you have already lived in that country for a period and speak the language well,** you may not need to do more than keep your language skills up by listening to foreign radio.
- **If, however, you have never learnt the language, and you are starting from scratch,** you may need some intensive language tuition, or even an immersion course, to ensure that your skills develop quickly enough.

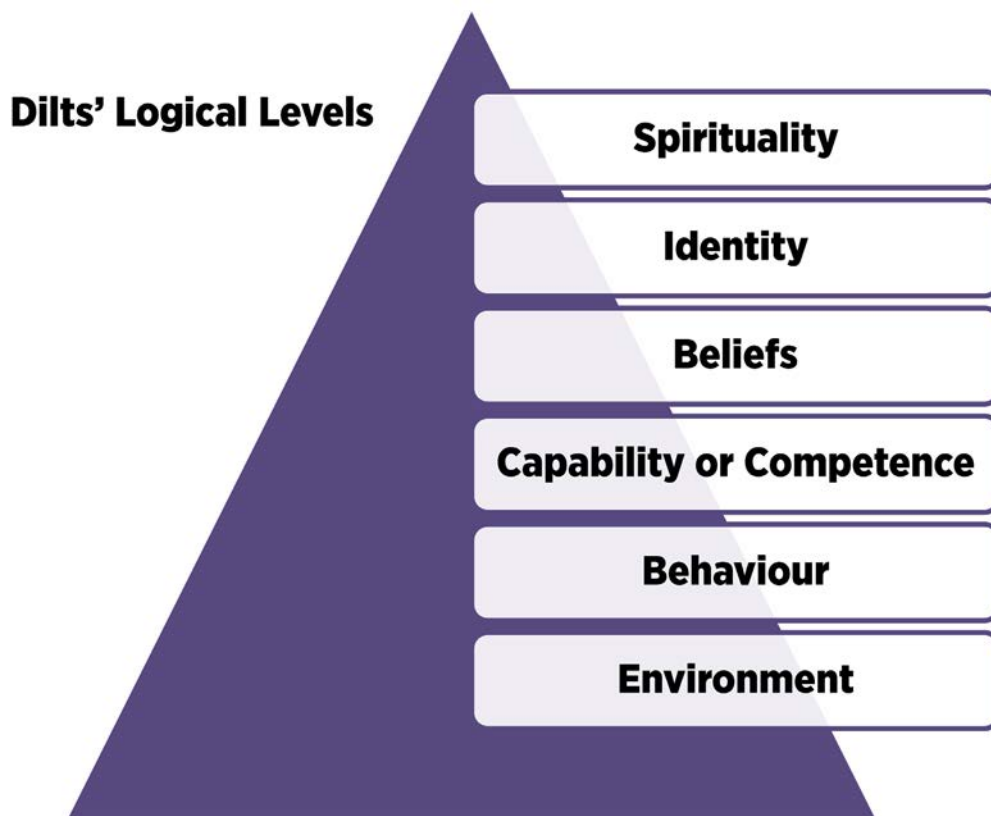
Be honest with yourself about this.

It is no good telling yourself that you will be able to develop a skill quickly or without support when you have no previous experience in that area. It is better to improve more quickly than planned than the other way round!

5. Identifying the Level of the Problem

Once you have identified the broad area of weakness or challenge that you want to work on, it can be helpful to dig a bit deeper. There are a number of 'levels' on which any problem can be expressed, and these will need to be addressed in different ways.

Dilts' theory of logical levels explains that there are a number of 'logical levels' that provide a helpful structure in which to look at problems or change (see Figure 3). The idea is that each level affects those below, and is affected by those above. If you want to change something, you therefore need to understand the level at which it operates.



Identifying the level of the problem can help you to frame both it and a solution more effectively. You can often identify the logical level by the language you use to describe the problem. For example, you may say:

- **Environmental.** I can't do this now. It's too noisy to concentrate.
- **Behavioural.** This is too difficult for me. I can't do it.
- **Capability.** I don't know how to do that.
- **Beliefs or Values.** This just isn't useful to me. I can't be bothered to spend time on it.
- **Identity.** People like me don't do things like this.

The key is to address the problem at the level at which you have framed it.

If you have framed it as being about your identity, it is no good trying to address it by going somewhere quiet to help you concentrate. Instead, you need to think about why you have those views about 'people like you', and try to unpack that a little.

6. Focusing on What Matters

You have now, therefore, identified some weaknesses, and also worked out at what level you have framed the problem, and the need for change.

The final step in identifying what to work on is to focus on what matters.

It is important to remember that you cannot do everything at once. Instead, you need to prioritise. One very good way to do this is to list all your areas for development, then ask yourself two questions about each one, answering on a scale of one to five:

- How important is this to me?
- How essential is it to develop it now?

Add together (or multiply) the scores for the two questions for each area, and you will have a much better idea of which areas to focus on first, because they are either more important, or they are more time critical.

Leave the other areas for a later date: next year, or even a few years' time.

Your ideal list of areas to address should be four to five key skills or areas of knowledge. Any more, and you will start to feel overwhelmed by the task you have set yourself.



Keep Celebrating the Good

As you work on your personal development, you may find yourself feeling a bit negative about yourself, because you have so many things 'wrong' with you. It is therefore helpful to keep a longer list of things that you are good at somewhere to hand for those moments.

Planning Your Development Process

The final step in planning your personal development is to identify how you are going to get from A to B: from where you are now, to where you want to be.

Just as with your vision, it can be helpful to break this down by time: in a month/six months/a year, what will you have done on the way to your ultimate goals?

This makes it easier to check your progress and keep yourself on track.

Now that you have identified areas of strength and weakness, and prioritised the most urgent and important for action, Chapter 4 provides some information about practical activities to do, and some philosophies and tools that you can use to help you to start the process of personal development.

4

Identifying Suitable Learning Activities

Choosing activities for personal development can be a challenge in itself. There is a wide range of options available, including formal courses, mentoring, learning on the job, online resources, and personal reflection. How will you know what will suit you best, and help you to achieve your goals?

This chapter sets out some ideas to help you think through the options.



Learning Shape

A number of aspects of how you like to live and work may affect the way that you learn. These include your preferences about structure and direction, your learning style, whether you like to work with others, and the environment in which you work.



The SHAPE of Your Learning

The elements that affect your study and learning can be described via an acronym, SHAPE.

This stands for:

- **Styles.** There are a number of theories about the way in which we like to learn, or learning style. There is little evidence that any of them are actually accurate, but it is certainly true that using different styles can help to keep you interested.
- **Habits.** We all develop habits over time, and these may be more or less helpful. To improve your habits, you need to identify the bad ones, and retrain yourself.
- **Attitude.** Your learning is affected by your beliefs and your mindset.
- **Preferences.** As well as habits, we all have preferences for our learning and the environment: hot, cold, the lighting, company and so on. These will affect how we learn.
- **Experience.** Previous experience also influences preferences: a good or bad experience under particular circumstances may affect how you approach similar circumstances later. It is worth considering this when thinking about why you might prefer particular learning options.

The next few sections discuss each of these in turn.

Learning Styles

The idea of a learning style is that we all have a way in which we prefer to learn. For example, some people like to sit down and read about a subject while others prefer to get on and have a go at it. In practice, the situation is not usually quite as clear-cut as this, because preferences can change over time, and when you are required to do different things at work and in life more generally.

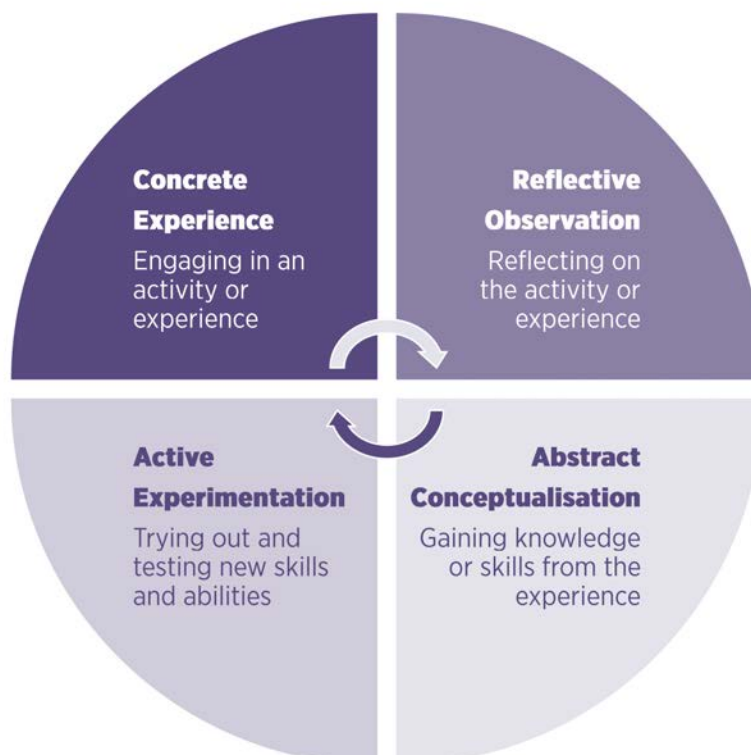
However, an understanding of your preferred learning style(s) may help you to find new ways of studying that work better for you.

Kolb's Experiential Learning Cycle

Kolb's learning cycle proposes that we all learn from our experience in a cyclical way (see Figure 4).

People observe something happening and reflect on their observations. This experience and reflection are then incorporated into the theoretical knowledge that the person already possesses, or supported by reading and training, building up a framework into which to fit their experience. To complete the cycle, people then need to be able to practice the new skills they have learned.

Kolb's Experiential Learning Cycle



Four Different Learning Styles

Kolb proposed this as a cycle, and there is no question that we all go through the cycle when we learn something. However, we also all prefer to start in different places and to spend more time on some aspects than others.

Peter Honey and Alan Mumford noticed this and built on Kolb's work to propose the theory of **learning styles**. They identified four separate learning styles:

- Activist
- Pragmatist
- Reflector
- Theorist

- **Activists learn by doing**

They don't want to hear what they should be doing, they want to dive in head-first and have a go

Activists are likely to say:

Let's just give it a go and see what happens

Can I try it out?

- **Reflectors like to think about what they're learning.**

They want to understand things thoroughly before they try them out

Reflectors are likely to say:

Let me just think about this for a moment

Don't let's rush into anything

- **Pragmatists care about what works in the real world.**

They aren't interested in abstract concepts, they just want to know if it works

Pragmatists are likely to say:

How will it work in practice?

I just don't see how this is relevant

- **Theorists want to know how their learning fits with previous theories.**

They are likely to be uncomfortable with things that do not fit with what they already know

Theorists are likely to say:

But how does this fit in with [x]?

I'd just like to understand the principles behind this a bit more

To learn effectively, it is important to be able to use all four styles, but most people have a preference for one or two. Particularly common mixtures seem to include Activist/Pragmatist and Reflector/Theorist.

One of the criticisms of the theory of learning styles is that it is possible to learn and develop other styles, so learning style preferences change over time. People often notice that their learning style has changed in response to different job demands or changes in their life.

These four styles are therefore best thought of as different ways to address problems, and to approach learning, rather than anything that is fixed and unchangeable.

VAK Model of Learning

One of the most common models of learning styles, taught to teachers and therefore familiar to many children, is based on Neuro-Linguistic Programming (NLP).

It describes learners as Visual, Auditory and Kinaesthetic and describes how you prefer to take in information.

- **Visual learners prefer to take in information by seeing** and often process it in pictorial form. This means that they will often think or remember things in pictures and like to read, see graphs, and use symbols.
- **Auditory learners prefer to listen and take information in by what they hear.** They favour lectures and discussions over reading.
- **Kinaesthetic learners learn by experience** and particularly by tactile exploration of the world. They prefer to learn by experimentation.



Use of Language: Identifying How Someone Thinks

You can get clues to whether someone is using a visual, auditory or kinaesthetic style from the kind of language that they use.

- Visual thinkers will use phrases like 'I see what you mean', and 'Let me get the picture straight in my mind'.
- Auditory thinkers will be more likely to say 'I hear what you're saying'.
- Kinaesthetics, on the other hand, will 'feel your pain' and give you a hug.

Practical Implications of Learning Styles

There is no question that each of us has particular preferences for how we learn. There is equally little doubt that we all have slightly different things that we are good at, which may or may not be related to our learning style.

The original theory suggests that we should tailor learning experiences to fit our preferred learning style.

Unfortunately, there are a huge number of theories of learning styles out there, and very little evidence that teaching in a particular style is beneficial for a particular type of learner.

A major review study looked at the VAK model of learning styles, and suggested that in order to prove that it was useful in teaching, you would need to have studies that grouped students by learning style, and then taught part of each group in different ways. There would need to be teaching methods that worked best for each type of learner and did not work for the others. The review authors concluded that there had been almost no studies that did this.

The jury, therefore, is still out on whether teaching should be tailored to learning styles.

However, just because there is no evidence from a formal study does not mean that considering your learning style is not worthwhile.

A knowledge of learning styles may help you to identify different ways of learning that might be enjoyable or better for you. For example:

- **Activist ways of learning** include brainstorming, practical experimentation, role plays, group discussion and problem-solving.
- **Pragmatist study styles** include case studies and time to think about the practical applications of what you are learning.
- **Reflector-style learning** includes spending time reading around a subject, and watching others try things out.
- **Theorist learning** involves models and theories, with plenty of background information.

Whatever your perception of your preferred style, it is important not to discard other experiences without trying them out. You may find that they work very well for you, either routinely or under particular circumstances. Understanding that there are different ways of learning, and that learning ideally happens in a cycle, helps you to vary your learning experience, and that is likely to improve your ability to learn and to retain information.



Adapt, Don't Abandon

If you find one particular way of learning difficult, you can always try to adapt your experiences.

For example, if you struggle with sitting in a lecture, listening to someone talk, try doing something different (additional) to help you.

Take notes, or draw a picture such as a mind-map to help you remember it more visually, or organise a discussion session afterwards over coffee with others to consider the learning in a different way.



Habits and Learning

We all develop habits over time, which may be more or less helpful to learning effectively. To improve your habits, you need to identify the bad ones, and retrain yourself. There is a useful process that you can go through to address this:

1. Identify what is stopping you or holding you back

Over the course of a few days, take time to notice what you are doing, and what stops you from learning or working effectively. This might include, for example, that you find it hard to settle down to work, or get easily distracted, or that you struggle to work in the evenings.

2. Identify the habit behind that problem

The next step is to dig a bit deeper, and work out what you are doing that is causing the problem. For example, do you struggle to get started because you spend time checking your email or social media, or because you are trying to work at home when your children are there, and they are distracting you? If you are tired, consider whether your sleeping habits or bedtime routine may be part of the problem.

3. Decide what you are going to do differently

Having identified the potential cause of your problem, you now need to decide what you are going to do about it. For example, if you have identified that checking social media is distracting you, try switching it off for a period, or set aside a time to check your social media, and plan to work or study at a different time.

4. Do it!

Research shows that it takes an average of 20 days to form or break a habit. In other words, you have to do something for 20 days routinely before it becomes a habit. Similarly, to break a habit, you need to avoid it for that long.

It does not matter if you lapse a little every now and then, but try to remember this principle.

Attitude and Mindset

Research shows that the most important factor in whether people learn and develop is the way that they think about their ability, or their mindset.

Most of those who have achieved greatness, to use Shakespeare's phrase, have worked extremely hard to get there. Many were told that they would never amount to anything, but they believed that they could achieve, and worked hard to do so.

Fixed or Growth Mindset?

There are two ways to view intelligence or ability:

- **Ability is fixed or ingrained.** In other words, we are born with a certain level of ability and we cannot change that. This is called a fixed mindset.
- **We can develop our ability through hard work and effort.** This is called a growth mindset.

These two different beliefs lead to different behaviour, and also to different results. For example, students with a growth mindset were shown to increase their grades over time. Those who believed that their intelligence was ingrained did not; in fact, their grades got worse.

Having a growth mindset (the belief that you are in control of your own ability, and can learn and improve) is the key to success.



Praise and Success

This issue of mindset is why you should never praise children by talking about their ability, but instead describe the effort that they put in, and how much they have learned and developed their ability through the activity.

Don't say: Well done. You're really good at maths.

Do say: That's great. You tried really hard, and look how well you've done.

It is important to praise the process, not the talent or ability.

Mindset in Practice

People with these two mindsets actually think differently and also react to information differently. In particular, they respond differently to information about performance.

- **In people with a fixed mindset**, the brain is most active when they are being given information about how well they have done, for example, test results or grades.
- **In people with a growth mindset**, the brain is most active when they are being told what they could do to improve.

It is a very different approach: from ‘How did I do?’ to ‘What can I do better next time?’. One is about how they are perceived, and one is about how they can learn. You can see which one is likely to lead to better results in future.

Dealing With Setbacks

These mindsets also cause people to deal with setbacks differently.

- **People with a fixed mindset** are very discouraged by setbacks, because a setback dents their belief in their ability. They tend to become uninterested and give up.
- **People with a growth mindset** view a setback as an opportunity to learn. They tend to try harder in an effort to overcome the problem.

“The moment that we believe that success is determined by an ingrained level of ability, we will be brittle in the face of adversity.”

Josh Waitzkin - Chess Grandmaster and Martial Artist

Neuroplasticity – Changing Your Mindset

The good news is that you can change your mindset.

Neuroscience shows that our brains continue to develop and change even as adults. Old dogs really can learn new tricks.

The brain is actually quite like plastic, and can be reshaped over time, forming new neural pathways. This has led neuroscientists to call this tendency neuroplasticity. These neural pathways are developed by doing or thinking particular things. The things that we do or say more often become hard-wired into our brains as habits. These form defined 'routes' in our brain, which become easier to use.

You can, however, still change them. The first step is to realise that you need to, then to train your brain in the new skill. It may help to think about this learning as a cycle.

There are three key things that you can do to develop a growth mindset:

- You need to recognise that **a growth mindset is not just good, but is also supported by science**. In other words, you need to be committed to developing a growth mindset.
- You can **learn and teach others about how to develop and improve their abilities through adopting a growth mindset**. This will help you to take control of your life, which is hugely empowering. Research shows that people who feel in control tend to perform better. It is a virtuous cycle.
- **Listen out for your fixed mindset voice**. When you hear that little critical voice in your head telling you that you can't do something, reply with a growth mindset approach and tell it that you can learn.

Identifying Your Preferences

Identifying your preferences for learning and studying is relatively straightforward, but it can make a huge difference to the effectiveness with which you learn.

There are four main areas to consider: structure, direction and drive, working with other people, and environment.

Structure

Structure refers to how organised you like your work and your workspace to be.

- **People who prefer a relatively structured approach** tend to make lists, keep their workspace very tidy, and use bookmarks and tags to ensure that they can find the information they want. They also tend to work within a routine.
- **People who prefer a relative lack of structure** tend to remember things in their heads, leave their papers out on their desks or workspaces, and study what interests them that day.

It is important to stress that both approaches are valid. If you are familiar with Myers-Briggs Type Indicators (MBTI), the level of structure is similar to the Judging-Perceiving (J-P) spectrum in MBTI.

However, both approaches also have their advantages and disadvantages. For example:

- **Those who prefer an unstructured approach** have a very flexible approach to learning, and are likely to be able to stay interested. They may, however, tend to miss deadlines, especially in areas in which they are less interested.
- **Those who prefer a structured approach** are likely to be very productive and get things done. They may, however, find that they struggle with tasks that call for creativity, and might benefit from introducing more flexibility to their thinking.

Anyone who tends towards one or other extreme needs to consider how to adopt elements of the other approach. This will broaden their skills and thinking, and make them more rounded and capable.

Direction and Drive

This element describes whether you like external direction, or prefer to drive and develop your projects in your own way.

- **People who prefer external direction** will tend to like clear assignments. They will appreciate being given a structure around their learning (for example, teachers, tutors or lecturers providing an overview of the course content early on). They may prefer clear guidance about how to approach problems, and ideas for how to start.
- **People who prefer less external direction** like to develop their own ideas. They will prefer to find their own sources of information, and not need a clear structure to lectures or courses. They will prefer to try things out for themselves, and not be told what to do.

This matters because it affects your attitude to your work and study, and whether you find it worthwhile and satisfying. It is worth taking time to consider your preference in this area, and seeing if you can tailor your learning or work to fit it better.



A Question of Approach

Judith's boss, Richard, was always keen to tell her how to do things. Every task that he set her was carefully outlined, so she knew exactly what to do.

It was driving her mad. She hated being told what to do and just wanted a chance to show that she could think things through for herself. Even when she asked him not to tell her what to do, but let her try her ideas first, he still couldn't seem to stop himself.

Fast forward a month or so: Richard left his post. In his absence, Judith was free to work as she wanted. She loved being able to do her own thinking, and ask Richard's boss for advice when necessary.

When her new manager arrived, she was careful to explain her working preferences. Her new boss was happy to respect these, especially since Judith had demonstrated her capability in Richard's absence.

Fast forward a few years, and Judith was a team manager herself. Remembering her early experiences, she was always careful to ask team members whether they preferred guidance from her before they started, or to do some thinking first, and then to respect these preferences in how she delegated work.

Working With Other People

Some people prefer to work with other people, and others prefer to work alone, and do their own thinking first.

This element is closely related to the Introvert-Extrovert (E-I) domain of Myers-Briggs Type Indicators. Again, both approaches are equally valid, and it is important to respect others' preferences.



Potential for Misunderstanding?

It is possible for this preference to lead to some serious misunderstandings.

For example, if you prefer to work with others, but you work or study with someone who prefers to work alone, you may need to give them time to do their own studying before you start discussing things together. They will probably come to your shared time/ discussion fully prepared, with their ideas in order and a clear view.

You will therefore need to be prepared for them to be irritated that you have done no preparation for your shared study time because, to you, it is important to discuss things together first! A compromise position might be to find another extrovert, and have a discussion ahead of the formal shared study time.

Environment

Finally, your study environment can very much influence the effectiveness of your learning. This can be divided into issues of high and low stimulus.

- **People who prefer high levels of stimulus** will probably prefer bright lights and background music. They may be able to work in places where there is a lot going on: a café, for example. They may prefer to move around when working, and also work on several things at once.
- **People who prefer low levels of stimulus** will tend to be easily distracted by noise or lights. They may prefer to work in a quiet room with lower light levels, and reduce the temperature of the room.

It is important, however, to remember that all stimuli are not the same. Some people work well with one stimulus, but not another (for example, they may want bright light, but no noise, or a cool temperature, but background music). Preferences may also change for different types of work.

The crucial issue is therefore to understand your own environmental preferences, and the circumstances under which you work most effectively for particular types of work.

Understanding Drives Effectiveness

For all four elements outlined here, understanding your own and others' preferences will increase your effectiveness. It is therefore important to take a bit of time to think about these issues before launching into work or study.

Experience

Our previous experience, including in learning and studying, can affect how we approach future experiences. This process may be both conscious and subconscious.

The key to managing this is to increase your awareness of what is happening, and ensure that you apply logic to the situation. In other words, be aware of your response to particular learning situations, and try to understand whether this is similar to other people's reaction. If not, consider why your reaction might be different, and whether this is genuinely justified or not, **in the current circumstances.**



Planning Your Learning: Some General Principles

There are a number of general principles it may be helpful to follow when planning your learning, and deciding on activities. They include:

- **Address your weaknesses**

Your weaknesses are what will stop you from achieving your goals. You therefore need to address them through your personal development activities.

However, there is a range of positions between focusing on your weaknesses to such an extent that you have hopes of turning them into strengths, and doing enough to get you over the barrier.

Only you can decide how much you want to do, and which end of the spectrum you wish to adopt.

- **Support your strengths**

The ‘flip side’ to working on your weaknesses is to remember that you have a number of strengths. Rather than neglect them altogether, it can be helpful to deliberately do things that will strengthen your strengths.

The reason for this is that your strengths are your key marketable abilities: they are the things that will get you your next job or promotion. You may need to overcome your weaknesses as well, but without those strengths, you are unlikely to be able to ‘sell’ yourself to a potential employer.

- **Think about what you *need* to achieve**

One important factor in your approach to learning activities is what you actually need. For example, if you have decided to do some practical development activities to improve your skills and make you more employable, you need to consider what skills you need. However, you also need to consider what will make you more attractive to potential employers.

Professional qualifications such as project management certifications or similar can be extremely useful ways to improve your skills and demonstrate your ability to potential employers.

Approaches to Learning

The jury may be out on whether learning should be tailored to suit your learning styles and/or preferences. There is, however, no doubt that including several different methods of learning in your overall plan will help you to maintain interest.

Options include:

- **Formal courses or learning opportunities**, whether leading to qualifications or not;
- **More informal learning experiences** such as reading, mentoring or shadowing;
- **Applying your formal learning** in a particular situation, to see what happens; and
- **Direct learning from your own experience**, through a process of reflection and expertise transfer.

The most obvious option for learning is probably via a formal course of teaching or training. However, many other opportunities are available, and many of them are free. Which you choose, and when, will depend on many factors, including financial implications and value. Formal courses and qualifications usually cost money, but you may get better value from them.

If a formal course of learning is not for you, it is worth considering other options.



Formal Courses and Qualifications: An Alternative View

There is a place for formal learning, of course. Many people embark on formal training or seek qualifications every year. However, if you can't afford to pay, and your organisation will not fund your development opportunity, don't despair.

- Explore options for grants or bursaries that could fund your learning.

There are plenty of organisations that may be prepared to help, especially if you fall into certain economic groups, or work in particular sectors (for example, the voluntary sector). Do some research and see if you can find at least partial funding. This could bring your course within reach.

- Be flexible about providers and/or style of learning

Some courses are more prestigious than others—but you may find that you can get what you want more cheaply by being flexible about your provider and/or style of learning. A fully remote course with the right curriculum could be both cheaper and a better fit for you than one that requires in-person attendance.

- Build your own learning experience from online providers

There are now many, many learning options online—and not just Skills You Need. Universities offer MOOCs, Massive Open Online Courses, that anyone can join. Providers like Coursera list enormous numbers of short- and longer-term courses. Much of this content is free or relatively cheap to access. You can therefore build your own course and curriculum to match your learning needs for a fraction of the cost of a formal university-led course.

Transferring Expertise From Other Areas

Expertise transfer is the process of drawing on your existing areas of expertise and learning to apply them in slightly different ways.

Rather than being a way of developing your skills, it is effectively a way of seeing your existing skills in a new light. This allows you to make sense of your challenges by using what you already know from another setting. The key to expertise transfer is to identify something that you are really good at. Many people, especially when they are finding something difficult, find it hard to identify anything at which they are ‘expert’.

In this case, it means something:

- That you can do relatively easily;
- Where you do not need to be supervised; and
- That you like or, at worst, feel comfortable doing.

It is helpful to identify something that has several stages to it, rather than just one.



Expertise Transfer in Practice

- Identify the key challenge that you are facing, in as much detail as possible. For example, you may find it hard to do written work because you never quite know where to start.
- Identify something that you do really well. This might be at work, or outside work, at home, or when you were studying, or a hobby.
- Think about and list all the skills that you use to do that thing well. Whatever level of detail works for you is fine, but do think about them carefully in terms of not just the skill, but what you do with it.
- Think about how each of those skills might help you do the challenge that you have identified. Again, think about what you might do with the skill to help you address the challenge.
- Finally, consider whether your challenge now ‘makes sense’: do you have the skills you need to do the job? Hopefully you will find that you do—and if not, you need another option.

Mentoring and Learning

You can learn a lot from other people.

One good way is via networking: talking to people in your field, both your peers and those who are more experienced than you.



Networking

Networking is an essential career management skill. There is more about how to do it effectively in *The Skills You Need Guide to Career Management*.

You can also choose to establish a mentoring relationship with someone, either informally or on a more formal basis.

This section explains more about the process of mentoring from a learner's point of view. In particular, it focuses on what a learner needs to do to get the most out of a mentoring relationship, and the skills that you will need to use to manage the relationship.

At the start, it is likely that the mentoring relationship will largely be controlled by the mentor, who will take responsibility for managing the process. However, as the relationship grows and develops, you, as the learner, will probably increasingly take control to ensure that it focuses on your learning needs.

The most basic requirement is an open mind.

The key skill from the learner's point of view is to be prepared to learn. It helps to have some idea about your learning style, so that you can ask your mentor to work in a way that will help you to learn best.

Choosing a Mentor

Choosing a mentor needs to be a positive process, not a passive acceptance of an imposed pairing.

If your organisation is running a mentoring programme, it is very likely that they will have a process that will offer you a choice of mentors. If so, you should think carefully about what each one can bring, as well as what you might be able to learn from and with them.

Talk to the potential mentors.

Explain to them that you're exploring whether a mentoring relationship with them would work for you. You can't decide without meeting them face-to-face, and you've got to be certain that you could work with them.

You're going to be exploring your learning, what you want to achieve from your career, what you've done well and what you've done badly, and so on. Some of those discussions will involve personal thoughts and experiences, so it's important that you feel that you can trust them.



Keep an Open Mind

Don't discard any potential mentor because they aren't quite what you were expecting.

A potential mentor doesn't necessarily have to be someone senior to you. They could be at your level, or even below, but much better than you at particular skills.

If your organisation has a matching process, and you have been matched with that person, there is a reason. Go and explore it. You may be surprised.

There are no hard-and-fast rules about whether mentoring relationships work best with similar people or complementary types. The important issue is whether you're prepared to try it, and see how it goes.

What Do You Want to Achieve?

You will also find it helpful to think through what you want to learn from the mentoring relationship.

The best way to do this is to start broadly, by thinking about questions such as:

- What interests me?
- Where do I want to go?
- What do I need to learn to move in this direction?

You may also find it useful to think about whether you want your mentoring relationship to focus on a wider area, such as your career within the organisation, or your skills development with a view to a change in career, or something narrower such as the way that you are managing a particular project or task.

This will help you think about how long you want the relationship to last.

A personal SWOT analysis (see the section on this in Chapter 3) can help you to identify areas of weakness and a potential focus for the mentoring relationship. This can feed into your choice of mentor, and whether you want someone who will complement your areas of weakness or someone who is generally quite like you and will understand where you struggle.



A Final Word of Warning: not all mentoring relationships work.

With the best will in the world, some mentoring relationships are much more productive than others, and others work best at specific times or for a short period. It is often not possible to know in advance which will work best, or how long a productive relationship will last, because such relationships depend very much on the dynamics between partners.

It's hard, but if the relationship is not working, and you don't feel that you're getting what you want out of it, then sometimes the best thing to do is to cut your losses. Under these circumstances, you need to be honest that it's just not working for you and you'd rather find another mentor.

Much better that than wasting any more of your own and your mentor's time.

Job Enrichment and Job Crafting

Sometimes it is possible to change your job to provide you with the personal development opportunities you want or need.

You may be able to do this yourself, or it may need the support of your manager.

This approach recognises that we are all individuals, with individual needs—and that very few jobs have absolutely fixed tasks or responsibilities. There is usually scope to tweak jobs and tasks to fit individuals' skills and development needs. This process is known as job crafting and job enrichment and is discussed further in Chapter 8 of *The Skills You Need Guide to Career Management*.



Learning From Mistakes

One of the most powerful ways to learn and develop is from making mistakes.

Nobody would advocate deliberately setting out to do things wrong. However, mistakes happen to everyone, especially if you are prepared to take risks and try something new. You can either treat mistakes as things to be hushed up and never spoken about again, or as learning opportunities. Making mistakes:

- Gives you a chance to do things wrong, and then reflect about how you could and/or should have done them differently; and
- Can, if you are lucky, uncover real truths about good ways of working and improve relationships.





A Cautionary Tale of a Lost Temper

Jan was not in a good mood. She had been under a lot of pressure at work. She was a civil servant, managing a small team, all of whom were working very hard and very long hours to meet demands from their senior managers and from ministers for more and more work.

She was currently chairing a meeting of about fifteen people, many of whom were from voluntary organisations. The meeting had been going on about an hour, and the voluntary organisation representatives had spent most of the hour complaining about the lack of support from Jan's team. So far Jan had listened politely, but her temper was starting to fray as she explained for perhaps the third or fourth time that the voluntary organisations were very welcome to do some work on the area if they wished.

'But,' said one of the senior representatives, 'we will need your team to provide some secretarial support. If we could just have two people for a few hours a week...'

Jan looked round the room, at the voluntary organisation staff nodding vigorously, and the other civil servants studiously not meeting her eyes, and she lost her temper.

'Look,' she said angrily, 'this policy area is just not a priority for ministers. My team is working flat out on other things that ministers are actually interested in. If you want this work done, you're going to have to do it yourselves. I can present it to ministers for you, but beyond that, no.'

She stopped, appalled. She had tried so hard to be conciliatory, and now she had just thrown several months, if not years' worth of relationship-building straight out of the window. There was a long pause in the room. Then one of the voluntary organisation representatives said, slowly,

'Thank you for telling us the truth. Nobody's ever been honest with us about this before in two years of working on this. We knew there was something wrong, but not what. We'll set up some working groups and report back to you at the next meeting.'

The relationship improved enormously after that episode, and the group started to work together much more effectively.

Potentially, losing her temper was a huge mistake for Jan. She certainly took away the lesson that self-control was vital and that she needed to work on it. However, she also never forgot the importance of being honest with other people about priorities.

It is not always easy to learn from your mistakes, however. In many organisations—and, indeed, among many individuals—there is a tendency towards allocating blame for anything that goes wrong, rather than a focus on learning from the experience.

It is, therefore, important to develop a personal process that will enable you to learn from your mistakes and move forward positively. With luck, this will influence those around you too.

One possible process might be:

1. Take responsibility: own your error

You cannot learn if you are not prepared to take responsibility for the error. In practice, this may also mean ‘taking the blame’, which may feel counter-intuitive.

However, if you are prepared to own your error, you will be able to take action to put it right, openly and transparently. We generally favour people taking responsibility for their own actions. It is seen as a sign of integrity and honesty. Being prepared to own your errors will therefore improve your reputation in the long term. You will also avoid the reputational damage of people finding out that you were responsible from another source.

2. See mistakes as an opportunity to learn

Owning your mistakes is not just about being able to take steps to put them right. It is also about learning from them, and ensuring that they don’t happen again.

To do this, you need to reframe them. You have to stop thinking of them as embarrassing, career-damaging, or negative in any way. Instead, you have to start thinking about them as highlighting lessons for you and others, or for the organisation as a whole. After all, if you made that mistake, others could do so too. Your actions now could prevent that happening in future.

3. Analyse your mistake in detail

The next step is to analyse your mistake to identify exactly what happened and why.

This doesn’t mean that you have to dwell on it miserably, constantly thinking about what went wrong. Instead, you need to examine it carefully, looking for the root cause, as a way to prevent it from happening again. There are several techniques that you can use (the box below outlines two possible options).



Techniques for Analysing Errors

1. Four questions

Ask yourself:

- What was I trying to do?
- What went wrong?
- When did it go wrong?
- Why did it go wrong?

2. Five Whys

The ‘five whys’ technique is a well-known way to explore the root causes of problems and mistakes. The technique is simple. You start with a statement of the problem: in this case, the error that occurred.

You then ask why that occurred. Once you have an answer, you ask why again, and dig deeper into the cause of the answer. You repeat this until you have asked ‘why?’ five times. This is generally enough to have reached the root cause. You can then consider what to do to address it.

This process highlights what went wrong, and also the action that is needed to avoid it happening again.

4. Put the lessons into practice

Identifying the root causes and the lessons from your mistakes is actually the easy part.

The difficult bit is what comes next: putting it into practice.

Unfortunately, when you are busy—which is, of course, when most mistakes happen—it may be tempting to just slip back to your old habits or approaches. It takes time to learn a new habit or work on a new skill, or develop a new process.

At this stage, you may need to revisit your personal development plan and add some new objectives or activities to help you to embed your new learning.

5. Review your learning

Finally, you need to take time to review your learning—which is why it is a good idea to include something about this in your personal development plan!

Chapter 5 discusses the process of reviewing your learning in more detail.

Build In Accountability

It can be helpful to build in a process that makes you accountable for your learning.

For example, you might make your goals public via social media, or in some other way, so that your friends will hold you to account. You could also find yourself an accountability partner. This is someone who is motivated by similar goals to you. You share your goals with each other, then check in with each other daily or weekly to keep each other motivated and make the goal bigger than yourself.

When you tie your success to someone else's success it can create an unstoppable force.

An accountability partner might be a friend or colleague, or someone you know from elsewhere. It is best if they already know you, and if you share similar goals.



Talk to Your Manager

It may be worth discussing your goals and development plan with your manager—even if your ambition is to move beyond your current organisation. There are several reasons for this:

- Your manager may have useful input into your planning process, especially if you want to move upwards in the same industry or organisation;
- You need to be confident that your plans will not leave your current colleagues in the lurch. For example, you may want to attend an event—but your manager may point out that it is at your busiest time of year.

A Final Process: Revisiting Your Personal Development Plan

Once you have decided on your chosen activities, you should update your personal development plan to reflect your decision. It is helpful to include details of your goal, how you plan to achieve it, and how you will know whether you have succeeded.

For example, if your goal was to become more confident in giving presentations, you might have:

Goal. By six months' time, to be able to feel confident about giving a presentation at an event with at least [x] attendees.

Strategy. To read up on ways to improve my confidence, then start practising with smaller events, working up to [particular event] on [date].

Measure of success. Within the next month, I will have found at least three possible ways to improve my confidence by using the internet and asking for advice from colleagues. Within 3 months, I will have tried them all at different events, and recorded my views about whether they work. I will also have sought feedback from trusted colleagues about their perceptions of my presentations each time.

This process will help you to hold yourself to account for your development. Chapter 5 talks about the importance of reviewing and reflecting on your personal development.

5

Reviewing Your Personal Development

Chapter 3 explained why it can be helpful to document your goals and plans for personal development, especially if you want to develop particular skills. Once you have planned your development, you can then go on to develop the skills that you have identified.

This is not, however, the end of the process, because it is important to review and evaluate your development.

This reflective process has two main purposes:

- To check that you have actually followed your development plan; and
- To ensure that your planned development has helped you towards your goals.

It also allows you to look again at your goals, and if necessary, update them.

A regular review process can therefore lead to you revising both your goals, and your planned development activities. This chapter explains more about this process.



Formal or Informal?

Just like developing your goals, reviewing and reflecting on your learning can be either formal or informal. You do not necessarily need to document everything in minute detail. The key is to use the level of formality that works for you and your learning.

Introducing Reflective Practice

Reflective practice is, in its simplest form, thinking about or reflecting on what you do.

It is closely linked to the concept of learning from experience, in that you think about what you did, and what happened, and decide from that what you would do differently next time.

Thinking about what has happened is part of being human. However, the difference between casual 'thinking' and 'reflective practice' is that reflective practice requires a conscious effort to think about events, and develop insights into them. Once you get into the habit of using reflective practice, you will probably find it useful both at work and at home.

Reflective practice bridges the gap between the 'high ground' of theory and the 'swampy lowlands' of practice. In other words, it helps us to explore theories and to apply them to our experiences in a more structured way. These can either be formal theories from academic research, or your own personal ideas. It also encourages us to explore our own beliefs and assumptions and to find solutions to problems.

Developing and Using Reflective Practice

Neil Thompson, in his book *People Skills*, suggests that there are six steps to developing effective reflective practice:

- **Read** around the topics you are learning about or want to learn about and develop.
- **Ask** others about the way they do things and why.
- **Watch** what is going on around you.
- **Feel**. Pay attention to your emotions, what prompts them, and how you deal with negative ones.
- **Talk**. Share your views and experiences with others.
- **Think**. Learn to value time spent thinking about your work.

In other words, you need to do more than just think. You also have to develop an understanding of the theory and others' practice too, and explore ideas with others.

Reflective practice can be a shared activity. Some social psychologists have even suggested that learning only occurs when thought is put into language, either written or spoken. This may explain why we are motivated to announce a particular insight out loud, even when by ourselves. However, it also has implications for reflective practice, and means that thoughts not clearly articulated may not endure.

It can be difficult to find opportunities for shared reflective practice when you are busy. If you are employed, there may be some obvious opportunities such as appraisal interviews, or reviews of particular events, but they do not happen every day. You therefore need to find other ways of putting insights into words.

It can be helpful, especially at first, to keep a journal of learning experiences.

Your learning journal should enable you to take everyday activities and events, and write down what happened, reflecting on them to consider what you have learned from them, and what you could or should have done differently. A learning journal and reflective practice can also highlight when you have done something well.

Keeping A Learning Journal

The most important aspect of keeping a learning journal is probably simply to get started. However, there are some things to consider, including:

1. Choose a format that makes you feel comfortable

Thirty years ago, anyone wanting to keep a journal was basically going to use pen and paper. Now, however, there are many more options.

You can still use pen and paper if you want—but you could also keep an electronic diary, either just for yourself or as an open blog, or a video log (vlog), or even an audio journal. The choice is yours, but choose something that you feel comfortable doing. If you aren't comfortable with it, you won't do it—certainly not very often.

2. Complete your journal regularly

It is a good idea to try to write or record something in your journal each day.

You don't have to write an essay each time. Instead, just set aside 10 minutes each day. Try to identify at least one point that you thought worth noting. If you want to write more, then that is fine—but try to make sure you at least do something each day.

3. Consider using a structured process for completing your journal entry

Especially when you first start keeping a diary, it can be hard to know what to write. Using a process can help to structure your thoughts, and focus you onto the learning from your experiences each day. The box below describes the reflective learning process, which may be a useful starting point.

Once you get more experienced, you will probably find that you want to combine steps, or move them around, but this is likely to be a good starting point.



The Reflective Learning Process

Identify a situation you encountered in your work or personal life that you believe could have been dealt with more effectively.

- Describe the experience

What happened? When and where did the situation occur? Any other thoughts you have about the situation?

- Reflect on the experience

How did you behave? What thoughts did you have? How did it make you feel? Were there other factors that influenced the situation? What have you learned from the experience?

- Theorise around the experience

How did the experience match with your preconceived ideas, i.e. was the outcome expected or unexpected? How does it relate to any formal theories that you know? What behaviours do you think might have changed the outcome?

- Experiment with the outcome

Is there anything you could do or say now to change the outcome? What action(s) can you take to change similar reactions in the future? What behaviours might you try out?

More simply, you could just use a structure like:

- **Background.** What was the situation
- **Action.** What did I (or others) do?
- **Result.** What effect did the action have?
- **Learning.** What have I learned as a result, and what will I do differently next time or when it happens to me?

An alternative structure is:

- **What happened?** Write a sentence or two to set out the background and remind you of the event. It might be something that happened to you, or something that you witnessed.
- **How do I feel about it?** You may want to write down both how you felt at the time, and how you feel about it later, as you write.
- **Now, what *really* happened?** This should be your objective assessment of the event, and its underlying causes.
- **What points do I want to note?** What do you want to remember about this event or experience? What lessons can you take from it?

- **What do I want to do differently as a result?** What are you going to try to change in your behaviour as a result? Remember, this may not even be something that happened to you. It might be something you saw that has made you think '*No, I don't ever want to behave like that when I am in that position*'. Note it down.
- **What do I need to do or achieve to make this happen?** Do you need to take any action to achieve your change in behaviour? If so, what action will you take, and by when?
- **How will I know that I have succeeded?** Make a note of your success measure, so that when you review this later, you will know whether you have succeeded.
- **How does this link to my personal development plan?** If your personal development plan is appropriate and 'right' for you, your learning points and reflections will fit within it and link to it fairly neatly. There will always be the odd event that comes 'out of left field', but still seems worth noting. However, most of your learning should relate back to your overall plan.

HINT: if most of your learning points do not fit within your personal development plan, you might want to revisit your plan—because it's clear that your plan doesn't set out what you want to learn!

4. Remember that the obvious event may not be the one that most matters

When you are completing a journal entry, you don't always need to include the big 'set piece' events. You may have attended a big meeting, and feel that you ought to write about that. However, if what really struck you was an interaction with your boss just before you left for the meeting—then write about that.

It's your journal, and it should record your learning: the points that matter to you.

5. Be honest with yourself

This learning journal is for you. You will not get much benefit from it if you are not honest. It is no good telling yourself that everyone let you down, and none of it was your fault. That is not going to help you learn—or help you develop as a person.

Instead, be honest about what you write. Take responsibility for your actions—and your mistakes.

Be your own 'critical friend'. You are not helping yourself by hiding from reality.

6. Include both positives and negatives

It is always easier to focus on what you did wrong, and dwell on your mistakes.

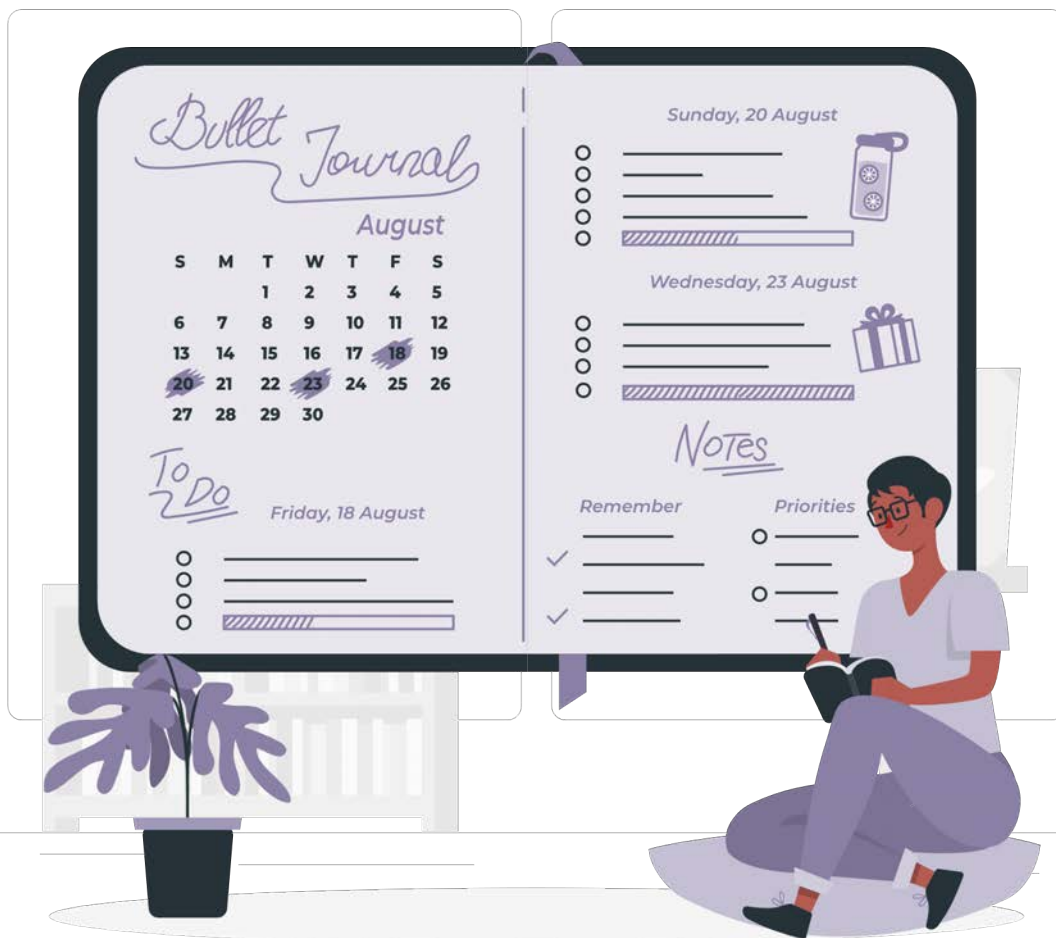
However, it is worth taking the time to remind yourself each day about one thing that you feel you did well.

This will help you to feel better about your development, and remember how far you have come already.

7. Use your diary or journal to help you review your progress

Your journal is a record of your experiences and learning. It is therefore a reminder of your progress in your personal development journey. Use it to help you review your progress, both periodically, and whenever you feel the need for a bit of a boost.

It is a good idea to link your learning back to your goals and personal development plan on a regular basis, just to check that you are making progress in the right direction! Your learning journal can be a useful tool in this process.



The Benefits of Reflective Practice

Reflective practice has huge benefits in increasing self-awareness, which is a key component of emotional intelligence, and in developing a better understanding of others. Reflective practice can also help you to develop creative thinking skills, and encourages active engagement in work processes.

In work situations, keeping a learning journal, and regularly using reflective practice, will support more meaningful discussions about career development, and your personal development, including at personal appraisal time. It will also help to provide you with examples to use in competency-based interview situations.



A Focus on What Matters

Reflective practice is one of the easiest things to drop when the pressure is on. However, it is actually one of the things that you can least afford to drop, especially under those circumstances. Time spent on reflective practice will ensure that you are focusing on the things that really matter, both to you and to your employer or family.

Evaluating Your Personal Development

As well as regularly adding to your learning journal on an ongoing basis, evaluating your personal development may involve regular and more formal reviews of your activity and learning.

It is worth taking time to review your activities against your plans every quarter or so. Less often, and you may find that you are not placing a high enough priority on your development activities, and letting progress slip. More often, and you are likely to find that you have not made enough progress, or that you are tempted to put the review off, because the last one was so recent.

Regular review will ensure that you keep tabs on your activity, and are not tempted to make personal development a lower priority.

It is easy to forget about personal development, especially if you have just started a new job or course of study. A regular review of your development plan keeps the process on track.



The Reflective Learning Process: A Possible Review Process

1. Set aside time for your review.

It is no good trying to reflect meaningfully in just five minutes. Make sure you are in no rush, and also that your environment is conducive to quiet reflection.

2. Find your original plan, with your goals and planned activities.

You need to know what you said you were going to do.

3. For each planned activity, assess how far what you have done by way of activity was in line with your plan.

Ask yourself:

- How much did I do?
- Was it as much as I was expecting to achieve?
- Did I do something different, but more effective?

4. Consider how successful you feel your development has been in getting you to your goals.

Have you made progress towards your goals? Have you identified more activities that will need doing that might slow down your progress? Are your goals (and their timing) still realistic?

5. Decide what you need to do next.

Is it more of the same, or something different? Do you need to take more time, or find some external support, perhaps?

6. Revise your plan to set out your new activities.

An Annual Review Of Personal Development

Even if you review your activity against your plans each quarter, it is also helpful to review them each year too, and think generally about what you have learned in the course of the year, as well as your progress against your plans.

If you are employed, your employer will probably have an annual employee appraisal process in place. Done well, this type of process enables you to review your achievements over the year, with input from your line manager, and reflect on what you have achieved, what you have learned, and what you would do differently in future.

The challenge is that most employee appraisal processes are not used effectively by either those being appraised or their line managers. They tend to be 'tick-box' exercises to be rushed through as fast as possible.

It is therefore worth taking the time to use your developing skill in reflective practice to reflect on your personal development, and progress towards your goals.

In this process, you should:

- **Review your goals, and make an honest assessment of your progress**

If you have achieved them easily, ask yourself if you aimed too low. If you have not achieved them, is that because you did not really want to do so, or you aimed too high, or your goals have changed?

Try writing down how you feel about your goals now, and if necessary, change them to reflect where you really want to be and what you want to do.

- **Review your achievements over the period**

Even if you have not reached your goals, what have you managed to achieve? Be honest about how you feel about what you have done well, and give yourself permission to be pleased and to celebrate.

- **Review what you have learned**

Think about what you have done over the period, and what you would do the same and/or differently if you had to repeat those tasks. Also consider what you have learned about yourself, for example, your priorities or goals, and your working preferences.

- **Make a note of your review**

You should, at this stage, make a note of the outcome of your reflection and review. This is particularly helpful if you are going through an appraisal process, but will also help you to keep an overall record of your achievements.

Celebrating Success and Dealing With Failure

An important part of personal development is being able to celebrate success and deal with failure.

“If you can meet with triumph and disaster, and treat those two imposters just the same...”

Rudyard Kipling, *If*

It is important to celebrate success. In a world that constantly pushes us to aim higher and higher, always looking for the next goal, it is easy to forget how far we have come, and what we have achieved.

Taking time to celebrate your successes, large and small, ensures that you mark the milestones on your personal development journey.

Why Celebrate Success?

There are two main reasons to celebrate success.

1. First, because we build achievement on success.

Many people find that they are inspired by their success to aim higher and further. Each promotion, each pay-rise, or each job successfully completed, encourages them towards the next goal.

They are motivated by having a goal to aim towards, and they find it useful to mark its achievement even as they look forwards.

Being successful helps people to see that they can be successful again. Celebrating success is therefore an important part of building self-confidence and self-belief.

2. Second, because we also need to see how far we have come.

The process of personal development tends to push us 'onwards and upwards'.

We are encouraged to review our goals on a regular basis to see if they have been achieved. If we have achieved them, the tendency is then to set new ones designed to stretch us further and to encourage us to achieve more. In other words, rather than focusing on what's been achieved, we look at what's still to be done.

Doing this, however, simply encourages us to look further up the mountain of self-development. There is always more that you can achieve, more skills that you can develop, another promotion to aim towards. This constant striving for more tends to make us dissatisfied.

For the sake of our mental health, sometimes we also need to look at how far we have come. We need to see the distance that we have travelled and recognise that this, in itself, is an achievement.

The journey matters too—and that means the individual milestones along the way.

Being prepared to look back and celebrate the milestones can help to make us more resilient when we suffer setbacks, because we know that each setback is only temporary.

There are also physiological reasons to celebrate success.

Celebrating and, indeed, feeling successful actually causes chemical changes in our bodies. It releases endorphins into our brains, which make us feel good. This, in turn, reinforces success and makes us more likely to want to do it again. It is, therefore, intrinsically motivating to celebrate success, especially if we do it in the right way.

How to Celebrate Success

Chapter 2 points out that definitions of success vary from person to person. How we choose to celebrate will also vary.

This is perfectly acceptable, but you need to be aware that how you choose to celebrate may affect your motivation.

In particular, if you decide to reward yourself with something material—and especially if you offer yourself a bribe (that is, you tell yourself beforehand that if you achieve something, you can have a reward)—then next time, you may find it harder to do what is necessary without a reward. In other words, providing a reward is a form of extrinsic motivation. This is less powerful than intrinsic motivation, doing it simply because you want to do so.

Ways to celebrate that support or provide intrinsic motivation include:

- **Reflecting on your success**, and considering what you could do even better next time, as we have described in this chapter.
- **Including others, especially if they have contributed to your success.** This helps you to remember that it is very hard to achieve on your own. Everyone likes being thanked, so this will also strengthen the connections between the group and make everyone more likely to work well together next time.
- **Take time to do something that you enjoy**, for example, going for a walk, watching the sunset, or simply spending time with people you love.

A Final Thought

It may be hard to take time to celebrate success, but it is worth doing, for several reasons.

If you only ever dwell on the negatives—what you didn't achieve, rather than how much you have done—then you tend to get very discouraged.

Celebrating your success helps ensure that you can keep going, and also that you enjoy yourself on the way.

Dealing With Failure

Celebrating success is therefore important, but how do you manage when you fail to achieve your goals?

Some people seem much more able to pick themselves up and dust themselves down after these experiences than others. These people are not intrinsically ‘better’ in any way: they have simply developed some positive habits and skills that help them to overcome failure and turn it into a more positive experience. In fact, they use failing as a way to learn and improve.

Understanding Failure

Some people, such as Rudyard Kipling in his famous poem *If...*, have suggested that success and failure are two sides of the same coin. In other words, neither really matters. Whatever happens, you have to pick yourself up and move on. This approach was perhaps typical of the Victorians. They felt that it was important to be able to win and lose gracefully—and that it was not appropriate to show your emotions, whether happy or sad.

We have perhaps become a little wiser about the importance of recognising and showing your emotions. However, being able to win and lose gracefully is still an attitude that it might be appropriate to cultivate.

Failing to win a sports competition, especially a major event that you have been working towards for several years, or to get a promotion or pay-rise, can feel devastating at the time. When you look back later over the whole of your life, however, it is unlikely to feature as one of your defining events—especially if you have later gone on to succeed in the same field. When humanity looks back over the last 500 years, your ‘failure’ certainly won’t feature.

In other words, it doesn’t really matter all that much to anyone else. In a few years, it won’t even matter to you. It makes sense that it shouldn’t matter now.

Of course, this is easier said than done, but there are things that you can do that will help make it ‘not matter now’.

Ways To Manage Failure

1. Recognise and accept your emotions

Failure hurts, at least in the first instance, and you need to accept that.

Trying to minimise your feelings or distract yourself can be counter-productive in the longer term. Just recognise your feelings for what they are and allow yourself time to hurt a bit.

Don't, however, dwell on it for too long. That, too, is counter-productive, especially if you blame yourself. Take a few days for the pain to lessen, and then start to move on.

2. Don't make it personal

One reason why some people find failure devastating is that their identity is tied up in succeeding.

In other words, when they fail, they see themselves as a failure, rather than perceiving that they have experienced a setback. Try not to see failure or success as personal: instead, it is something that you experience. It does not change the real 'you'.

This comes back to Kipling's point: success and failure are not intrinsic parts of you. No part of your identity should be 'I am a success' or 'I am a failure'.

3. Don't worry what anyone else will think

Sometimes our views about success and failure are tied up in what other people will think about us, or about how we think they will judge us.

You cannot ever control what other people think. Nor should you ever do something simply because it will please other people.

It is easier to accept both success and failure if you define them in your own terms, and do things because you want to achieve, not because you think other people will be pleased.

4. Take the right amount of responsibility

We have all met people who are always ready to blame others or events for their lack of success.

'The referee was biased!'

'The teacher doesn't like me, that's why my mark was so low.'

'If only I hadn't been ill last summer, I wouldn't have missed several weeks of training.'

It is important to recognise when other, external factors have affected your success. You don't need—and should not try—to blame yourself for everything, particularly if it is outside your control.

It is, however, also important to recognise what you yourself could have done to improve matters. For example, could you have trained or worked harder? Was your revision really all that it could have been? Did you really prepare for that interview in the best possible way?

Take responsibility for the factors over which you have control, and don't be tempted to hide behind excuses.

5. Use failure as a way to improve

Don't think of failure as failure. Instead, see it as life's way of showing you that you need to improve, and how to do so.

In particular, ask yourself what you could have done differently to achieve a better result. Then consider how you could put that into practice to help you to improve for next time.

Think about failure differently. Your approach to both it, and the future, will also be different.



Rising from the Ashes of Failure

In 1999, the England Rugby Union team lost to South Africa in the quarter-finals of the World Cup. Jonny Wilkinson, the fly-half, later commented that he had felt at least partly responsible for this disappointing and early exit from the competition, because he had not played very well. He said that this had encouraged him to work harder in the next few years.

Wilkinson was known for his obsessive approach to practising his kicking. He practised for hours each day from slightly different places on the field, until his accuracy became almost legendary.

In 2003, his persistence paid off. England won the World Cup in the final minute of extra time, with a drop goal from Wilkinson.

Would this have happened without the 'failure' in 1999? It is impossible to say, but Wilkinson himself certainly put some of the credit in that direction.

Winning and Losing with Grace

We try to teach children to win and lose games with grace: to accept the 'two imposters as the same'.

We tell them not to 'crow' or 'gloat' when they have won, and we encourage them to accept defeat when they have lost. As adults, the wins and losses may not necessarily be on the sports field, but perhaps we can all learn a little from the idea that failure is only temporary.



Reviewing Your Goals

Finally, as part of your review process, it is likely to be helpful to review your personal development goals. Ask yourself:

Are these goals *really* what I want to achieve more than anything else?

Do they inspire me to take action?

If the answer to either of those is 'no', then you probably have the wrong goals.



Changing the Picture

If you are struggling to identify goals, try doing something different.

For example, take yourself away for the weekend and go for a long walk. Walk up a hill and sit and look at the view.

Think about what matters to you. What do you *really* want out of life?

The advantage of going somewhere outdoors is that the landscape has been there a long time, and it has a way of making things look simpler. You can, however, do almost anything that takes you out of your usual environment and gives you time to think.

You may feel that the answer is '*I don't really have any goals right now, because I'm pretty happy with my life*'. You could, in that case, give yourself a break and stop worrying about personal development for a bit. But do come back to it in a few months, a year at most, and make sure that this is still the case. It is also important to remember that life has a way of moving on, and that even staying still can require positive action.

The answer, however, is more likely to be 'yes, but...'

In other words, yes, that is still more or less what you want, but you have refined your thinking consciously or unconsciously. In that case, tweak your goal until you are feeling more inspired, and it really is what you want to achieve more than anything else.

Once you have your revised goals, you can then go through the process of deciding what activities you need to develop your skills.

Moving Towards Reflective Practice

In time, regular review and reflection on what you have achieved should become a habit. The process outlined in this chapter of reviewing your plans and goals on a regular basis is a step in that direction. It ensures that you set aside time for reflection, and that you consider both your progress against your goals, and your learning and development more generally.



6

Recording Your Personal Development

Recording your personal achievements and movement towards personal development goals may seem unnecessary. You might think that you will not forget, and therefore there is no need to make a record.

Having a record of what you have done, however, is important for several reasons. This chapter explains more about the importance of record-keeping and suggests a process for doing so.

The Importance of Record-Keeping

The main reason for keeping a record of your achievements is to be able to demonstrate them to a potential employer.

They are, effectively, proof that you can manage the requirements of a new job.

Many job applications and interview processes nowadays are competence-based (and you can find out more about what this means in *The Skills You Need Guide to Getting a Job*). This means that you will probably be asked to give examples of times when you have used and demonstrated the skills required for the job. A record of your personal achievements is vital in doing so.

Reviewing your achievements, and recording them, is also a way to check your progress against your goals. While your personal goals are just that—personal—it can nonetheless be interesting to look back and see if they have changed. If you never record your goals and achievements, you have no way of seeing how you have grown over time.

Even if you are undertaking personal development for purely personal, non-work related reasons, it is still a good idea to record your achievements, although you may decide to do this less formally than the way described here.



Types of Record of Achievement

- **Certificates and formal records and certificates** Some personal development achievements will come with formal certificates: a degree, for example, or other qualification. Any certificates should be kept safely where you will be able to find them at short notice, because you may need them for an employer.
- **Informal third party records** Other informal records may also be written by others: a letter from your line manager praising your skills in a crisis, perhaps, or 360° feedback about your management skills. These are valuable evidence of your skills, and should also be kept securely.
- **Your reflections** Finally, you may want to record your reflections on your achievements: what you did, what you achieved, and what you learned from the experience. These records give you a set of examples of how you have demonstrated your abilities under different circumstances. This is slightly different from keeping a learning journal, but you might keep your records in the same book or place.

Recording Achievements

It is a good idea to keep a record of your main achievements: the things of which you are particularly proud, because you feel that you did them very well, or they were especially hard to do, and other people might not have managed.

These will form the basis of any competency-based job application, so it is a good idea to take time over this element of your record.

The box below suggests one way in which you might do this.



The Achievement Funnel

For each achievement, record:

- The date and time period;
- A brief background, including the task that you were required to achieve, or the challenge that you were set. Try to keep this to no more than two sentences;
- What exactly you did, as precisely as possible;
- The effect of your actions on the task and on others around you, and how they contributed to achieving the task; and
- The outcomes you achieved.

Remember that potential employers will be most interested in what you can achieve for them, so what you did, its effects and the outcomes are the most important elements. You may also find it helpful to briefly list the skills that you think you used for this achievement.

Recording Your Skills and Abilities

When you have a reasonable list of achievements, together with the skills you used, you may want to take this a step further, and start to list your skills and personal qualities, together with evidence (usually your achievements, but also your qualifications).

One way to do this is to list the skills that you have and/or want to develop, and for each one, provide:

- Two or three examples, in different settings, of **times that you have used this skill**. You will find your list of achievements very useful in developing this; and
- **Evidence that you possess that skill**. This might include, for example, an appraisal report or 360° feedback, or a letter from a colleague, as well as your own achievements.

You will want to update this list on a regular basis: at least yearly, although more often if you are going through a particularly rapid period of development, for example, because you are studying. It is therefore a good idea to keep it electronically, because this makes it easier to add new examples, and move examples to other skills if they now seem more appropriate there.

As you develop your skills and experience, you may wish to separate your skills into more nuanced areas. For example, instead of simply talking about 'communication skills', you may want to have separate examples for written and oral communication skills, or even different types of writing, or perhaps separate out your presentation skills.



Feeding Your CV

A potential employer will always want to see details of your education and training (including continuing professional development and similar courses) and your employment history. To be able to provide this, **it is a good idea to develop a good CV and keep it up to date**. You should always review it when you are actively job-hunting, but it is also a good idea to review it at least once a year, and check that your description of your current job, and your qualifications, are up to date.

The process described in this chapter will help you to develop examples that will feed your CV, and also your competency-based supporting statement or application form.

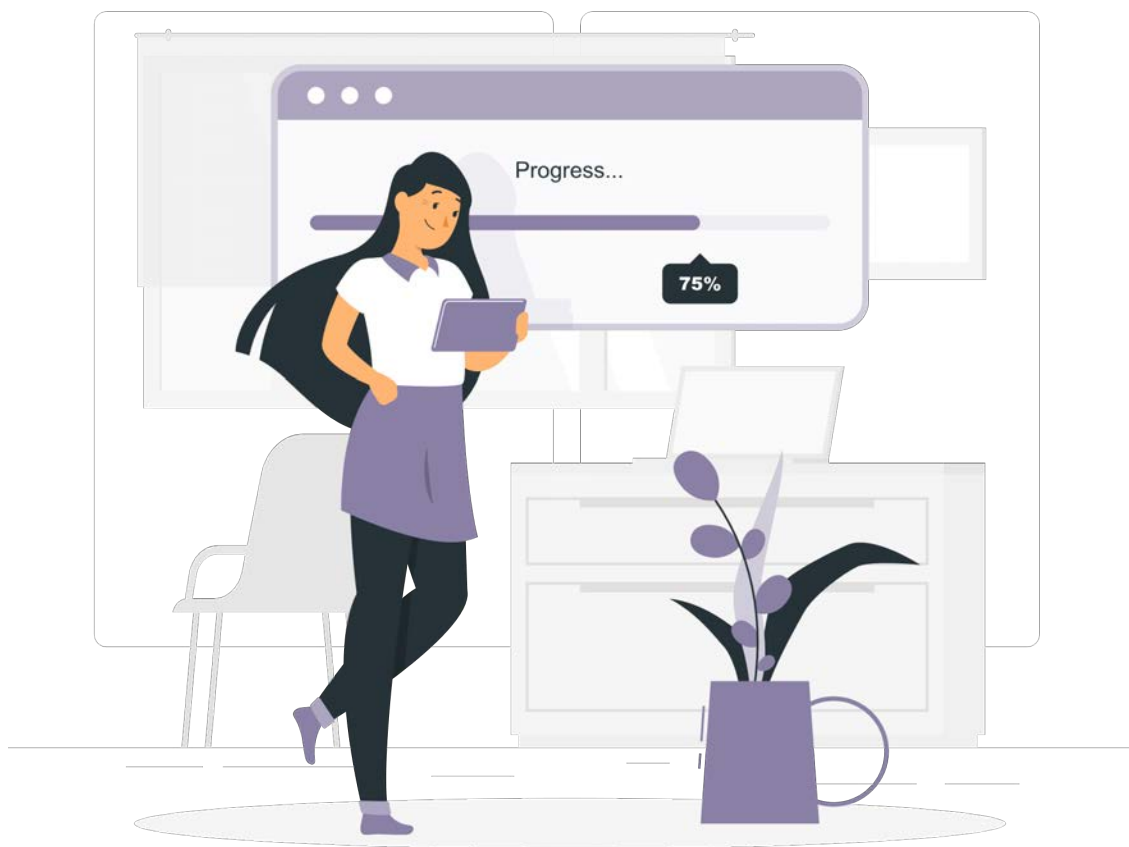
There is more about how to prepare a good CV and apply for a job in *The Skills You Need Guide to Getting a Job*.

Your Memory Is Not Infallible

Elephants may never forget, but most of us are not blessed with that kind of memory.

Keeping a record of your achievements is a way to ensure that you will be able to remember examples of when you used particular skills.

Reviewing your achievements is also helpful if you are finding life a bit tough. It reminds you of what you have achieved, and what you can do again, and may just give you the impetus to go out and get that new job.



7

A Special Case: Continuous Professional Development

Continuing professional development, or CPD, is the ongoing process of developing, maintaining and documenting your professional skills. It is therefore important both in keeping your skills up to date, and also documenting that process. It is, if you like, a special case of personal development.

Your professional skills may be gained formally, through courses or training, or informally, on the job or by watching others.



CPD: a formal requirement?

Some professions use the term 'continuing professional development' formally, and require a certain amount of development activity to be carried out and documented each year as a condition of maintaining your membership of, or registration with, a professional body, or a licence to operate in that field.

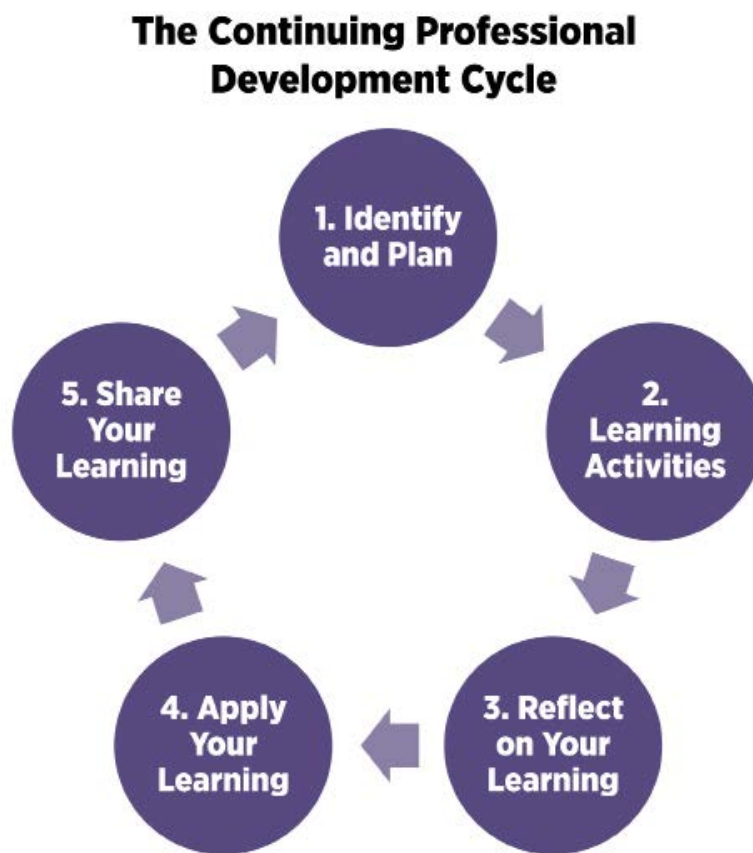
In other areas, the term is used more informally. However, a commitment to learning and improving is generally expected of anyone in a professional capacity.

The Continuing Professional Development Cycle

The process of CPD is designed to help you identify and act on your own development needs. Like much other learning, it is probably best thought of as a circular series of activities (Figure 1). The process moves from identifying your development needs through planning and then carrying out your learning activities, to reflecting on your learning, and then applying it and sharing it with others.

Perhaps the most important thing about CPD is that it is personal.

Individuals are expected to identify their own needs, organise their own training, and learn for themselves. Part of being a professional is taking responsibility for your own skills and recognising when they need to improve.



1. Identifying Your Needs

There are a number of ways in which you can identify development needs.

For example, you can carry out a skills audit. You may receive feedback from colleagues or your line manager about an area in which you are weaker. Alternatively, you may have an interest in a particular area and want to develop your knowledge.

Once you have identified your key areas for development, you then need to plan your activities.

2. Planning and Carrying Out Development Activities

Development activities may be either:

- **Formal learning**, such as training courses or particular qualifications. These are often, though not always, provided by an external provider, and may carry a cost. Your employer may have a limit on what they are prepared to pay, so you may need to consider self-funding or alternatives such as free or cheaper online resources.
- **Informal learning**, including side-by-side learning, video training (for example, for doctors in particular surgical techniques), shadowing, mentoring, coaching or reading on the subject. These have become much more common.

There is a growing recognition that continuing professional development is both essential and potentially expensive. Especially in developing countries, professionals are using the internet to share teaching content for free, or at very low cost. You may find that an imaginative approach to seeking out development activities pays off.

3. Reflecting on Your Learning

Reflecting on what you have learned is a vital part of continuing professional development.

Learning does not emerge only from activities that you designated as ‘development’, and you may find that you are learning at least as much from your day-to-day activities. For any formal or informal but designated development activity, you should record the activity, what you found useful or not useful about it, and what you have learned. In each case, make sure that you are clear about how it will change what you do in future (how you apply your learning).

It is also worth documenting particular learning from an experience in your day-to-day work, especially if you find yourself reflecting on it, and realise that it will change how you work.

4. Applying Your Learning

Going on training courses or watching videos is only the start. You then have to apply what you have learned to your own job.

This can be quite a clumsy process, especially at first. The competence theory of learning sets out that we move through four stages when we learn:

- **Unconscious incompetence.** Not knowing what we don't know.
- **Conscious incompetence.** Knowing where we need to develop and watching other people do it, but still unable to do it ourselves with any skill.
- **Conscious competence.** Being able to do something reasonably well, provided we concentrate.
- **Unconscious competence.** Being able to do something almost instinctively, without needing to focus on it.

When you have done some training or other development activity, you will probably be somewhere between conscious incompetence and conscious competence, depending on how much you have been able to practise.

You therefore need to spend time applying your learning and practising to move to a stage of unconscious competence.

5. Sharing Your Learning with Others

Some commentators add a fifth stage to the competence cycle – being able to teach others.

It is certainly true that being able to articulate and share your learning is an important part of making sure that you have fully internalised it.

It is a good idea to get into the habit of discussing your learning with your colleagues on a regular basis. Sharing each other's learning can be a really good development tool, and can help you identify new areas for development, or ideas for other development activities, as well as helping to refine what you have learnt in your mind.



Finding Time to Share Experience

It can be hard to find time to share your experience with colleagues, especially if any of you work remotely.

In remote or hybrid organisations, it is therefore worth creating opportunities to share learning. For example, if you have a regular team meeting, set aside some time to discuss development at each meeting. If you don't have a regular team meeting, it may be worth creating a monthly meeting to catch up with each other, including your learning, or using an app like Slack to discuss IT issues or learning about particular issues.

Recording Your Development

An important part of continuing professional development is being able to demonstrate it, especially if your membership of a professional body depends on it, or if you do a lot of contract or short-term work.

It is a good idea to keep a folder or portfolio of all your development activities, drawing on your learning diary. The aim of this is to be able to show how your skills and knowledge have developed over a period.

You should therefore:

- **Keep a note of your development needs and goals**, and make a regular (quarterly, six-monthly or annual) assessment of your progress against them;
- **Record any training courses attended**, including remotely, with a copy of any certificates or qualifications obtained. Keep a record of the date, provider, aims of the training, and your thoughts on what you learned from it;
- **Make a note of any shadowing, video-assisted training or similar**. In each case, record the provider, the aims, and your thoughts about what you learned;
- **For any coaching or mentoring sessions**, make a note of the date, the person you were with, what you discussed, and what you intend to do differently as a result;
- **For any reading and other informal development that you do**, make a note of the book or website, and what you have learned and will do differently as a result;
- **If you are involved in any critical incidents, or make particular mistakes from which you learn**, record the details of the incident, what you learned, and what you will do differently as a result.



The CPD cycle can be used in or out of work, and formally or informally

You can continue to use the CPD cycle to develop your skills, and document that development, during any career breaks or time out of the workforce.

Simply take time each week or month to reflect on what you have learned that week, whether through a formal course, or informal experience, and document it. This will help you to demonstrate your skills when you want to return to the workforce.

And Finally...

Continuing professional development is an ongoing process, as well as a cycle. You are likely to continue to learn throughout your professional life. It is therefore a good idea to develop a process for it that works for you at an early stage of your career.



Conclusion

When you first start thinking about personal development, it can seem as if you know nothing, and have no skills. You may find this point rather overwhelming! But it is important to bear two things in mind:

- **You *do* have skills.** You have been learning and developing all your life, and you already have many, many skills.
- **You do not have to improve everything all at once.** In fact, you are much better off not trying to do that. Focus on just one or two areas at a time, and you will see much larger improvements, and also feel less overwhelmed.

There is a reason why personal development is sometimes called ‘lifelong learning’: there is no time limit on it. Take it one step at a time, and it will seem much less daunting. We hope that this book will help you to do just that.

